

TEN TOES DOWN PRESENTS / THE COALITION EDITION

The Second Great Butch vs. Stud War

The Panorama of Games for Lillian

VOLUME 1 OF SIX

The Missing Treaty and the War over Entrance Music

Mystery, investigation and classic adventures

Forty real games. One coalition. Aiden has already overspent.

Fictional wars, adult coalition comedy, reclaimed in-group language and innuendo.

New ChatGPT prose under Nolan’s creative direction. The 1967 war is invented history.

Coalition Edition 3.0 - 20 September 2026

240 CASES / SIX DEPARTMENTS

ZERO OBLIGATION TO OBEY THE DEPARTMENTS

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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How to find a game in this book

Each game starts with a short pitch, what you actually do, the controls and pace, the main catch, and a first action to try. These practical sections use plain language. The longer Aiden scene comes after them.

For a fast comparison, read the pitch and main catch on two or three pages. Use the alphabetical index to jump to a title. Choose the full story only when you want the comedy; it is never a prerequisite for understanding the game.

This is an original comic game catalogue inspired by the Aiden ensemble in Ten Toes Down. The source novels remain separate. Game descriptions and catches are research-based editorial notes; the coalition summit and Aiden's rulings are fiction.

The catalogue ranges across possible fits and clearly marked detours. "Waits" describes the usual decision loop, not a certification that every scene is untimed. The labels mean: A place to start = a promising candidate; Read the catch first = a meaningful obstacle needs checking; A more demanding detour = a narrower or harder option. They describe the game, not the reader. Check the exact edition.

Choose any game directly. Skip any game for any reason. The elaborate route is an optional joke; declining never costs a token. No purchase, download, account or medical information is needed to use this book.

Print on Letter paper at actual size, or fit to A4. Page references use volume / page, which remain valid in the omnibus. For larger type, use the reflowable EPUB. Links and a full alphabetical index sit beside the printed case numbers.

The six departments

1. Suspiciously Interesting People - mysteries and adventures
2. Taking One's Turn - strategy and role-playing
3. Looking Around Before Doing Anything - exploration
4. Things That Fit Into Other Things - puzzles and construction
5. People Who Have Something to Tell You - character stories
6. Bringing a Friend - co-op and shared play

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Choose a game by its name

This is the quick route. Click any title, or turn to its page. Read the short pitch and main catch first; Aiden's scene follows the practical guide. The case number works across every format.

The long conversation: [The First War Had a Jacket and the Second Had a Default Setting](#) - page 40. Names, race and who gets treated as the default.

The historical field guide: [Lesbian lives, desire and politics across several histories](#) - page 106.

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The Coalition Has Arrived and Nobody Approved My Throne

"My niggas," I announced, "tonight we make history."

"Tonight you make the table level," Rae said. She put one hand on the wobbling treaty desk and looked at the champagne balanced on its corner. History slid toward her wrist. She caught the glass without looking impressed.

I had advertised the evening as BUTCHES VERSUS STUDS: A NIGHT OF HIGH-STAKES DIPLOMACY. Six rooms of games. A coalition signing. A drag programme. A private casino floor and enough gold trim to make a reasonably secure country reconsider its reserves. The printer had asked whether versus meant a debate. I had said it meant ticket sales. There were no tickets. I was paying for everybody.

The first Great Butch vs. Stud War had happened in 1967 at the Blue Comet Social Club. That was the story I had been told. The story was entirely invented, and within that invention I had already managed to receive three incompatible versions. A borrowed jacket, a disputed jukebox selection and an unsigned peace agreement appeared in all three. The alleged artillery was a handbag full of coins.

Auntie June, eighty-two and still a butch with excellent posture, said she had won. Odessa, eighty-four, a stud everybody called Dez, said June had invented the rules after losing. They arrived in the same car. June carried Dez's bag. Dez was wearing a jacket that June recognised from 1967. I asked whether that was a provocation. "It's chilly," Dez said.

I had promised them a Second Great Butch vs. Stud War with a definitive ending. They had asked whether dinner was included. The veterans were already better at diplomacy than I was.

Kit arrived with a suit bag, a library tote and the posture of a woman who had already decided the sound system was inadequate. "I'm here for the karaoke," she said. Rae pointed at the crooked table. "I'm here because somebody said there would be decent food." I showed them their rival lecterns. They immediately used both to support the table.

"My niggas," Tank whispered, watching my international architecture become furniture repair, "peace is expensive."

"We haven't begun the rivalry."

"Your rivalry is holding up a buffet."

Nia came through the door carrying a fountain pen and wearing a dress that made Rae forget the table for just long enough to look up. Nia was a trans lesbian, a lawyer, and the first person to ask whether the signature page was attached to anything. I told her the lesbian delegation was on the left and the trans delegation was on the right. She looked between the doors.

"I already belong in both rooms. Are you charging me twice?"

"No."

"Good. Your borders are stupid."

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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She took two badges, clipped them together and sat beside Rae. Kit asked for a spare badge because hers would look good on her jacket. Within five minutes my factions had become accessories. I had spent four hundred dollars on velvet ropes to describe people who could simply walk around them.

Mika, the trans nonbinary planner, unhooked one rope and rolled it into a circle. They had a radio, three miniature model hotels in their bag, and a schedule that treated my welcome speech as a removable obstruction. "We're signing a game-night charter," they said. "Not dividing Europe. Move your face."

The face was mine, printed nine feet high on a backdrop. I had been photographed looking toward the future. The future needed the fire door behind me. Tank and Remy carried me sideways while I watched my own expression approach a mop cupboard.

Remy had come to perform as King Receipts. He was a trans man, a drag king, and the owner of a fanfare that began with an actual cash-register noise. Velvet Payroll heard the rehearsal through the wall and came over in a robe that had its own relationship with gravity. "Darling, if that sound means somebody's paying me, play it again."

"It's my entrance."

"Then enter with an invoice."

She wanted a full set, good light and a cheque that cleared. He wanted a microphone that worked and a partner who would stop laughing before the end of his love song. They settled the order of their first rehearsal by playing rock-paper-scissors. I had commissioned a twelve-page dispute mechanism. Nigga, they had used their hands for three seconds and gone back to work.

Shawna found me beside the unused lectern. "You look troubled."

"They're forming alliances without me."

"That's the event."

She kissed me, adjusted my collar and told me that if the signing finished before midnight, we could form a very private bilateral arrangement upstairs. I began caring about administrative efficiency with an intensity my accountant had never seen. I asked Mika whether the programme could be shortened. They handed me my own speech with every page crossed out.

Darnell arrived with the wrong jacket and a contribution nobody had put on the hospitality rider. "Who authorised cocaine at a coalition signing?" Velvet asked. "My fee doesn't include arguing with somebody who thinks his yacht is a personality."

"It's a beautiful yacht."

"Then marry it. The water's already booked."

Rosa pointed him away from the game table. Dre put his casserole in the space he vacated and claimed the blue controller. I started a sentence about Crip diplomacy. "Nigga, I brought dinner," he said. "Don't give the casserole a foreign policy."

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Mercedes tried the microphone. Porsche checked the projector. Kit asked Rae whether she wanted to inspect the mystery games. Rae said yes, provided nobody made her sign an agreement to enjoy them. Nia held up the actual draft. "That clause is already gone."

"You read it?" I asked.

"I crossed out 'irrevocable fun.'"

"That was my best line."

"That's why I used the thick pen."

So here it is, Lillian: two hundred and forty games, six departments, and a summit full of grown people who can disagree about an entrance without surrendering a friendship. You can read the game cards, follow the ridiculous ceremony, enjoy the scenes or skip directly to a title that catches you. Nobody needs a coalition's permission to have a good evening.

I tried one final welcome. "My niggas, the treaty will bear witness to - "

"The table's level," Rae said.

Everyone applauded. Nia squeezed her hand. Kit turned on the karaoke screen. I had prepared a declaration of historic unity, and the first unanimous decision was that a woman fixing my furniture deserved the microphone more than I did.

Fair. Fucking humiliating. But fair.

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Campaign Record: The First War, 1967

A fictional document from the equally fictional Blue Comet Social Club. This is invented family-and-club lore for the comedy, not an account of LGBTQ history.

June drove a bus, saved her tips from a second job, and bought a jacket with a lining she described as expensive. Dez made clothes and described the lining as polyester with ambition. Both remembered the jacket as magnificent. Each remembered being the reason it looked good. On the night in question, June had put a coin in the jukebox. Dez had selected the record. June claimed ownership of the next dance by financial contribution. Dez claimed ownership by taste. The cashier claimed somebody still owed for two ginger ales. Every account omitted the ginger ales until the receipt turned up.

The first engagement occurred beside the coat rack. June asked where her jacket had gone. Dez said a jacket was only borrowed if the owner remembered lending it. June said that was the precise opposite of how borrowing worked. Dez said she looked good. June agreed, which has complicated every subsequent attempt to describe this as a clean military victory.

The second engagement involved the microphone. Neither woman had been scheduled to sing. Both later described the duet as an ambush. The club programme called it an unexpected highlight. A photograph shows them laughing so hard that the microphone has been pointed at a lampshade. June says this proves sabotage. Dez says the lampshade had a better sense of rhythm than the committee.

A peace agreement was drafted on the back of the hall-rental invoice. It provided for alternating jukebox selections, return of the jacket before winter and payment of the ginger ales. June signed the front. Dez signed the back. They put their names on opposite sides of the same obligation and each spent the next fifty-nine years saying the other had never signed.

No armies marched. The event was an extravagant name for a club feud, a dance, a little money and two people who liked having a reason to see each other again. Their friends called it a war because their friends were dramatic. I called the sequel a war because the banner company charged the same amount for any title under forty letters, and I had not counted.

Now the jacket was back in the room, the veterans were sharing a plate, and I had purchased a triumphal arch. June asked which side had won. I said the new coalition would settle the question. Dez looked at the arch. "Baby, the carpenter won."

The summit would hear both accounts. It would negotiate a present-day game-night charter, give the performers a stage, and hopefully finish before Shawna decided my private peace process had missed its final appointment. The old invoice was in a folder. The new invoice was considerably larger. My niggas, history had learned how to charge interest.

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Who Is in Which Delegation? Whoever Says So.

Rae is a Black stud lesbian and a bike mechanic who likes detective stories, excellent snacks and a signing table that stands up. Kit is a butch lesbian and librarian with serious opinions about karaoke and no reliable idea where she left her glasses. Their rivalry concerns this particular evening, not a rule about what either label means.

Nia is a Black trans lesbian, a lawyer with terrible handwriting, and a woman who wants a dance with Rae. She belongs to more than one caucus. Mika is a trans nonbinary event planner with a miniature-hotel collection and a suspicious weakness for spectacular staging. They will sometimes improve the plan by making it considerably more expensive.

Velvet Payroll is a Black drag queen who wants a paid show and a properly lit stage. She uses she/her in these scenes. Remy is a trans man and drag king, performing as King Receipts, whose awful puns have survived every soundcheck. Drag describes what they perform; it does not turn the cast into a single gender or orientation.

The veterans are Auntie June, a Black butch lesbian and retired bus driver, and Odessa "Dez," a Black stud lesbian and retired seamstress. Both are fictional. Their 1967 feud is remembered with affection, unreliable detail and an unreasonable interest in who still owns one jacket.

Aiden narrates and pays. Shawna is his wife and has plans of her own. Tank, Rosa, Mercedes, Porsche, Dre and Darnell bring the established Tellings party energy. All the people in these invented scenes are adults. Lillian remains the reader. The new summit cast and relationships belong to this generated companion, not to a claim about the source novels or real people.

The fictional crew's printed chorus is deliberately excessive: fifteen uses of the reclaimed plural on every fixed PDF page, including covers and indexes. It occupies a separate band. EPUB pages change with the reader's font and screen, so the reflowable edition carries the chorus at chapter boundaries instead. The practical cards remain ordinary readable descriptions.

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The Game Card Comes Before the Summit

Pick a genre or a title. Read the short pitch, what you actually do, the main catch and a first try. The longer explanation follows if you want it. The fiction comes afterward. You can understand why a game sounds interesting without reading a treaty, knowing the cast or doing any arithmetic.

The three labels describe editorial fit: A place to start is a promising candidate; Read the catch first identifies an obstacle to check; A more demanding detour is a narrower or harder possibility. The collection includes different levels of complexity. None of these labels describes the reader's intelligence or determines what they can enjoy.

The exact edition matters. An old adventure and its modern remake can ask for different movement, camera and inventory actions. Two people discussing one single-player mystery is different from a game with native co-op. The source notes keep these distinctions visible and leave unsupported features unknown.

The elaborate route is optional. A refusal costs nothing. You can stop, change games, ask for a reminder or prefer conversation. A first try is one meaningful action, not a prescribed duration or a test with a passing grade. This is leisure, not treatment.

The new coalition has no authority over your evening. "Then what are we signing?" I asked. Nia handed me the venue bill. "Your part is very clear." Shawna pulled out the chair beside her. The useful part of the evening was already happening there.

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The Coalition Has Created a Committee to Abolish Committees

Article 1. Enter through any door you like

Choose a department by what you want to do. Book I investigates suspicious people. Book II lets a turn wait for you. Book III looks around. Book IV moves ideas and objects into place. Book V listens to characters. Book VI brings company. A game belongs to one shelf in this Panorama so the count stays honest; its pleasures can overlap several shelves.

For the practical route, choose two titles from a shelf, read the catch, and try the more appealing opening. For the ceremonial route, continue below. The ceremony does not know better than you do.

Kit said the mystery room needed a better name. Rae suggested "the room with the mysteries."

Velvet proposed "Evidence, Darling." I offered "The Aiden Memorial Institute of Suspicion." "You're alive," Nia said. "And still talking," Rae added. Mika printed MYSTERIES on a sheet of paper and taped it to the door. The room became easier to find. My niggas had negotiated a sign by declining to negotiate with me.

Article 2. Name what the evening needs

Write or say up to three actual preferences: no required rush; no separate camera steering; avoid held input; few menus; light reading; little clue tracking; or native co-op. Add any theme you do not want. You can choose fewer than three or add your own.

These are boundaries for the selection, not traits assigned to a person. They can change next time. The record should read "tonight, no camera wrestling," not an assessment of somebody's capabilities. One is useful information. The other is a stranger wearing a clipboard.

A source gap is not permission to promise a feature. If we have not established how a game handles a requirement, its card is a question to check or a reason to choose another game. The optional web finder treats strict feature filters conservatively. The printed cards put the concrete catch beside the temptation.

Rae wanted no sudden rush and a place to put her drink. Kit wanted a story with somebody worth arguing about. Nia wanted to sit beside Rae. I began assigning each wish a ministry. "Nigga, hers needs a chair," Tank said. Nia pulled one over herself. The coalition resolved its first territorial question by moving furniture six inches.

Article 3. Choose a row, because the binder demands coordinates

Each department has forty cases. Pick one of five rows: 1, Quietly Curious; 2, Ready for a Conversation; 3, Willing to Inspect a Thing; 4, Here for the Atmosphere; 5, Open to a Wildcard. These are ceremonial mood names. They do not certify that every game on a row meets that mood; the actual card and preferences decide that.

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Choose a row freely. If you want dice, roll one ordinary six-sided die. Results 1-5 select that row. On a 6, visit the Incident Desk once and then choose a row yourself. There is no recursive reroll trap. The Incident Desk has had its authority to extend the evening revoked.

I called the mood rows a psychological instrument. Mika asked who had calibrated it. I said I liked the typeface. Velvet selected Here for the Atmosphere while adjusting an earring large enough to alter it. "My niggas, an instrument," Tank said, "is what Mercedes is trying to play while you explain the fucking menu." I left the mood rows to their modest work.

Article 4. Select the object whose paperwork you distrust

Choose an emblem, or roll an eight-sided die: 1 Envelope, 2 Key, 3 Plant, 4 Map, 5 Teacup, 6 Spare Chair, 7 Gold Stamp, 8 Clock. Read the corresponding column of the department's five-by-eight route grid.

The grid gives a case number. For example, department 1, row 2, emblem 3 gives local case 11, P011. Department 6 at those same coordinates gives P211. The same coordinates in different departments lead to different games. This is either a filing system or a multiverse, depending on whether you are speaking to Shawna or me.

Remy chose the Gold Stamp because it matched his jacket. Kit chose the Key because hers were missing. Rae selected the Spare Chair and immediately sat in it. I tried to explain that it was symbolic. "Then symbolically get another one," she said. Nia moved her bag. We had a perfectly good emblem and an actual seat, and I was the only person dissatisfied.

Article 5. Optional: give the evening an outrageously specific title

Write one short session trait. Examples: "Two Detectives, One Sandwich"; "The Map Can Come to Me"; "I Want to Know What She Meant by That"; "A House with Excellent Stopping Places"; "The Plant Is Lying"; "My Friend Has the Other Controller." A trait describes a taste or a situation, not a diagnosis.

Whenever it helps explain why a title sounds interesting, point to it. That explanation is already useful. You do not need a numeric bonus to care about a haunted town or a witness with a suspicious alibi.

If you enjoy the machinery, begin with three imaginary Stamp Tokens. Spend one to add two to the paperwork total OR reroll all four paperwork dice once. At most one token per selection. Refusing costs nothing; tokens never buy exceptions to preferences.

Velvet named her trait Paid Before the Encore. Remy chose Entrance Music Longer Than the Entrance. I wrote Historically Indispensable Host. Shawna put a line through indispensable. "Keep the rest," she said. "You did book the room." My niggas had discovered the cheapest possible way to reduce a national monument.

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Article 6. Four dice that cannot be cashed at the bar

Roll four ordinary six-sided dice. Each 1 or 2 means minus one, each 3 or 4 means zero, and each 5 or 6 means plus one. Add the four values. Your paperwork total is between minus four and plus four. This optional layer draws on Fate's familiar signed-dice idea; the surrounding selection rules are original Panorama rules.

If you spend a Stamp Token, either add two or reroll all four dice once and use the new total. You cannot buy a second modification on this selection. Reset to three tokens whenever you begin a new browsing session; no ledger needs to survive dinner.

The dice can produce a total from minus four to plus four. A +2 stamp can raise that part to plus six; the separate refreshment adjustment can add another zero, one or two.

Kit rolled and began calculating. Rae watched her pencil. "You always look this serious?" "Only when somebody's pretending numbers are fate." Nia smiled into her glass. Velvet asked whether a plus two could extend her set. Mika said the arithmetic selected a game. "Fine. My contract selects the encore." Two systems, both suddenly clearer than mine.

Article 7. Optional: the snack amendment

Record a separate snack adjustment: one if somebody has already brought the drink they wanted, plus one if wanted snacks are within reach and no one is expected to fetch them. The maximum snack adjustment is two. Keep it separate from the dice-and-stamp paperwork total; Article 8 adds it exactly once. If these conditions are irrelevant, use zero. This arithmetic is a joke about hospitality; nobody needs to eat or drink anything to participate.

Do not delay choosing a game to qualify for this amendment. Do not make a snack score into a task for somebody else. The best possible snack state is people having what they actually want.

Rae negotiated for better crisps. Kit supported her motion immediately, which spoiled my photograph of historic rivalry. Dre set down the casserole and Tank became the first delegate to support the amendment with both hands. "My niggas," I said, "let the record show - " Rosa gave me a plate. For once the record benefited from silence.

Article 8. The entirely unnecessary formula

First find the local case from the grid: eight times (row minus one), plus emblem. Add the paperwork total and the snack adjustment, if you used them. If the result exceeds forty, subtract forty until it is 1-40. If it is below one, add forty until it is 1-40. Otherwise keep it. The final local case number is always between 1 and 40.

Then add forty times (department minus one) to get the complete P-number. Department 3, row 1, emblem 2 starts at local case 2. A paperwork total of minus three and a snack adjustment of one gives zero. Wrap zero to forty. In department 3, local case forty is P120.

This is a shelf address. It is not a probability of enjoyment, a cognitive score, a ranking, or an instruction to buy something. It chooses a page to consider. Read that page's ordinary fields before treating it as a candidate.

If arithmetic gets in the way, use the offline finder or choose directly.

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Mika checked the formula. Nia checked the example. Rae checked whether Kit was using the back of the menu as scrap paper. I asked who was checking the atmosphere. Velvet looked over her shoulder. "I invoiced you for that, darling." The shelf address survived the inspection. My claim to be essential did not.

Article 9. Read the game first; Aiden can wait

Read the short pitch, what you do, main catch and first try before the longer comic scene. The full appeal and catch give the detail behind those summaries. Aiden's scene and verdict are fiction; a funny reason is not evidence for a game feature.

Check the exact edition and platform. A remake can change movement, menus and saves. A touch port can differ from a desktop pointer. A Steam store date may be the port's date rather than the original release. Local co-op, online co-op and two people discussing a single-player game are not interchangeable.

If the card conflicts with a real preference, reject the candidate. If it is promising but has an unresolved operation, check that specific operation before investing in it. "Can we select this inventory object comfortably?" is more useful than "Is this an easy game?"

The screen showed a beautiful landscape. I declared it perfect for everybody. Kit asked about the camera. Rae asked about holding buttons. Nia asked which edition I was looking at. "My niggas," Tank said, "you can't answer a control question with a sunset." I turned the card over and read the part I should have read first.

Article 10. The appeals court

You may make one ceremonial appeal or skip the ceremony entirely. To appeal, choose a neighbor: the previous local case, the next local case, or the same local case in another department. Wrap case 1 backward to 40 and case 40 forward to 1. Check the new card as usual.

After that one appeal, stop calculating. Choose either candidate, browse the direct index or close the book. Every route ends with a human decision; there is no compulsory loop, escalating fee or penalty for declining both.

If you would rather talk, talk. If you would rather stop, stop.

I appealed the seating chart because I was no longer in the middle. Nia asked whether I wanted to be near Shawna or near the photographer. I said both. Shawna held out her hand. The photographer moved to the buffet. My niggas, a constitutional crisis ended with one entirely reasonable choice, and I did not require a second hearing.

Article 11. A genuinely useful first session

Load the chosen edition before introducing its controls. Show one meaningful action. Keep a reminder if wanted. Find pause, save or exit so leaving feels ordinary. Do not turn a trial into a lesson with a hidden passing grade.

For a mystery, that might mean one conversation or one clue. For an exploration game, a nearby path and a place to stop. For a turn-based game, one decision with the menus already explained. For co-op, agree who wants which role and whether the roles have equal kinds of action.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
Niggas, lights on.	Niggas, mic check.	Niggas, take turns.	Niggas, dance later.	Niggas, read first.
Niggas, pick freely.	Niggas, no rush.	Niggas, sign here.	Niggas, stay petty.	Niggas, we're good.

Stop, change games or take a break whenever wanted. A day off makes room for leisure; it does not require a whole day of screen time. The useful note afterward is a sentence about what was enjoyable and where to resume.

Rae tried one clue. Kit had a theory. Nia listened and then offered a different one. Nobody asked me to introduce the game. I stood there with the microphone until Mika took it gently out of my hand. "There," they said. "Your first useful action." I went to find Shawna, who had saved me a seat without establishing a department for it.

Article 12. What these departments are allowed to claim

This is a researched, source-linked candidate catalogue with original comic writing. Game descriptions were checked against publisher, developer, platform or identified supporting sources. Control classifications and first-trial suggestions are editorial judgments unless tied to an explicit declaration. No card claims a complete-path playtest.

The catalogue deliberately contains different levels of complexity. Turn-based strategy and elaborate deduction belong here only for readers who want those specific demands. The direct index and catches let you pass them by. "There are two hundred and forty games" does not mean "all two hundred and forty will suit the same evening."

The offline finder uses the same case IDs as the books. It makes no network requests and does not inspect your library. Marking a title interesting does not install or buy it. Its strict feature filters require stated evidence; an unknown is not silently accepted.

I announced that the catalogue proved universal happiness was possible. Velvet asked whether I had tried every game. "Not personally." "Then put that on the same fucking poster." Nia uncapped the thick pen. My niggas, an honest limitation arrived with better handwriting than my slogan, which was impressive because Nia's handwriting was terrible.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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Twelve optional declarations of personality

1. Two Detectives, One Petty Rivalry. Choose mysteries you want to discuss. Conversation beside a single-player game is not native co-op.
2. The Coalition Can Bring the Map Here. Prefer a desk, static scene or fixed framing; check the actual movement and camera.
3. Velvet Has Questions for the Ghost. Supernatural stories may appeal; horror and bereavement still deserve a look.
4. Three Caucuses, One Comfortable Chair. An intimate setting can contain a rich story. A small world does not guarantee simple decisions.
5. My Turn Is Not a Diplomatic Emergency. Turn-based candidates can wait between choices while still having complicated menus.
6. You Have the Controller; I Have a Theory. Agree whether you want co-op, shared discussion or passing the controls.
7. The Plant Has Refused to Sign. Observation and occult mysteries; check the reference-book and clue-tracking work.
8. Rae Fixed the Treaty Table. Building can be absorbing. Confirm the desired mode and its control demands.
9. Nia Came for the Story and Stayed for Rae. Character interest can motivate a game; reading load and choice pressure remain separate questions.
10. Mika Reopened the Side Door. Explore because the place interests you; test movement and looking around before a longer journey.
11. The Puzzle Can Wait for the Encore. Use evidence about untimed play. A funny trait cannot establish a feature.
12. Aiden Has No Veto Over My Evening. Choose directly, stop or change your mind without spending a token.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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The incident desk

1. The rival lecterns form a table. Rae and Kit cooperate before Aiden can photograph the rivalry. Choose a row; repairing the furniture does not change a game feature.
2. Three badges, one delegate. Nia sits with both caucuses. Aiden orders another badge and receives another bill. Choose a row; no identity adds or subtracts points.
3. The drag programme has a rider. Velvet finds an unpaid rehearsal in the schedule. Mika finds a pen. Choose a row while the performance gets its own agreement.
4. King Receipts enters twice. Remy wants the cash-register fanfare to land properly. The second entrance is worse and he enjoys it more. Choose a row; no encore roll.
5. The cocaine is not a centrepiece. Darnell misunderstands the hospitality plan. Rosa clears the game table and Dre puts down dinner. Choose a row; no fictional drug affects the route.
6. The karaoke caucus expands. Kit starts a song and discovers Rae knows the harmony. Aiden loses his scheduled welcome slot. Choose a row.
7. The trans delegation has the actual key. Mika opens the side room everyone has been debating. It contains chairs. Choose a row; you do not have to hold a meeting to sit down.
8. A dance enters the minutes. Nia asks Rae directly. Rae says yes. Aiden tries to record a historic development and is told to find his own wife. Choose a row.
9. The blue controller has no foreign policy. Dre calls dibs, then offers to swap when somebody wants that seat. Aiden abandons his theory about international colours. Choose a row.
10. The treaty pen is a eyeliner pencil. Velvet retrieves her property. Kit lends an ordinary pen. Choose a row while the summit discovers affordable stationery.
11. Private negotiations upstairs. Shawna and Aiden leave their own agenda out of the public record. Tank can say choose a row without a ceremonial sash. Choose one whenever wanted.
12. The portrait receives no reimbursement. All caucuses agree the giant picture of Aiden was his own decision. Choose a row; unanimity is occasionally very inexpensive.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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A route that knows when to shut up

The shortest working procedure

First name up to three real preferences or vetoes: required speed, camera movement, holds, menus, reading, clue tracking or native co-op. Keep them beside you. The route cannot overrule them.

You are in Department 1. Pick one mood row and one emblem column below; neither claims to describe a game feature. That gives a starting case. You can go there now.

For ceremonial excess only, roll four ordinary six-sided dice: 1-2 means minus one; 3-4 means zero; 5-6 means plus one. Add the four results. Add zero, one or two for any already-available wanted drink and wanted snack. Eating is never required.

Begin a browsing session with three imaginary Stamp Tokens. At most once per selection, spend one to add two OR reroll all four dice. You may take an optional funny trait from Book I as your excuse. Never pay a token to refuse a game.

Move that many cases along this department’s forty-case shelf, wrapping around at either end. Read the real catch. If you want one appeal, visit the adjacent case or the same local position in another department; then choose freely or stop. No appeal loops.

The printed full rules, worked example and incident desk are in Volume I. The offline index performs the arithmetic and provides conservative evidence filters. The direct alphabetical index near the front always works without dice.

Mood / emblem	1. Envelope	2. Key	3. Plant	4. Map	5. Teacup	6. Spare chair	7. Gold stamp	8. Clock
1. Quietly curious	P001	P002	P003	P004	P005	P006	P007	P008
2. Ready for conversation	P009	P010	P011	P012	P013	P014	P015	P016
3. Willing to inspect a thing	P017	P018	P019	P020	P021	P022	P023	P024
4. Here for the atmosphere	P025	P026	P027	P028	P029	P030	P031	P032
5. Open to a wildcard	P033	P034	P035	P036	P037	P038	P039	P040

Local position = 8 × (row - 1) + emblem. Wrap modified position to 1-40. Global case = 40 × (department - 1) + local position.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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The Veterans Have Seen My Welcome Package

“Nigga, why have you declared war at a hotel?” Shawna asked.

The banner was still rolled up. That should have bought me time. Unfortunately, my wife could read the invoice. THE SECOND GREAT BUTCH VS. STUD WAR occupied its own line, directly above PREMIUM UNFURLING ASSISTANCE. I explained that war was a metaphor. She pointed at the next line. “Then why does your metaphor need a smoke machine?”

Auntie June arrived before I could develop a defense. Eighty-two, retired bus driver, Black butch lesbian, blue suit sharp enough to separate me from my excuses. Odessa, whom everyone called Dez, followed with a garment bag over one arm. Eighty-four, retired seamstress, Black stud lesbian, looking at June like she'd been returning the same overdue library book for fifty-nine years.

“The first war wasn't about the jukebox,” June said immediately. “It was about principle.” Dez took off her glasses. “It was about you putting your song on six times.” “People liked it.” “People left, nigga.” The legendary Blue Comet Social Club feud of 1967 had three surviving accounts, all contradicted by the two surviving people telling them. There was a borrowed jacket, a hall-rental agreement each swore the other had never signed, and a peace dinner that apparently ran out of potato salad before peace could develop.

I had heard this story at a cookout and made the reasonable leap to hiring a casino convention floor. My invitation promised rival entrances, a game night, and a coalition summit to settle unfinished business. June had accepted because she wanted to hear her song on a good system. Dez had accepted with June's jacket in her garment bag and a counterclaim about decades of excellent alterations. Everybody else had accepted because I'd said there would be food and interesting games. The relationship between those objectives and my budget was already deteriorating.

Rae arrived with a bike helmet under her arm and examined the signing table before saying hello. Black stud, mechanic, detective-story enthusiast, a woman capable of diagnosing a wobble from six feet away. Kit came behind her carrying a karaoke folder and asking where her blue entrance light was. White butch, librarian, soft voice, powerful opinions about a chorus. I gave them separate welcome packets. Kit opened hers. “Mine says we're bitter rivals.” Rae looked at the crackers. “I'm bitter about these.” They went together to find better ones.

Nia, a Black trans lesbian and femme, had received two packets, one for the lesbian caucus and one for the trans delegation. “Do I get two dinners?” she asked. “Only if you can carry both,” Rosa said. Nia smiled and stayed near Rae, who was making an excellent argument for actual olives. The contract lawyer had promised to inspect our evening's agreement. She had not promised to spend her whole night lawyering. Her other objective was a dance, though she hadn't yet decided how to ask for it.

Mika, our trans nonbinary event planner, put a tiny model hotel beside the registration tablet. “For scale,” they said. I thought they meant my ambition. They meant the floor plan. Velvet

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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Payroll, a Black drag queen with exquisite timing, swept in with a garment rack and a payment schedule. Remy, a trans man whose drag-king name was King Receipts, followed with a crown and the world's most aggressively cheerful fanfare. Velvet needed stage time. Remy needed a microphone that worked. Mercedes needed both of them to let her finish soundcheck. Porsche needed me away from the recording equipment.

Shawna took my hand. "I need my husband for part of tonight." I assured her that the husband was in exceptional operating condition. "Then stop leasing him to your own decorations." She looked beautiful, amused, and very close to putting me in a cupboard until I could behave.

Mika handed Rosa the silver folder while she cleared registration. Somewhere in that transfer I decided the welcome sign needed a stiffer backing. Elsewhere, I put the ceremonial pen down while checking my portrait. These were small decisions. History enjoys waiting until small decisions have become expensive before telling you which ones mattered.

June and Dez took chairs beside the first mystery game. The banner came down crooked. Tank stared at it, then at me. "These niggas wanted a party. You bought them a sequel." I reached for the folder to explain the agenda. It was gone. The pen was gone too. Shawna smiled without mercy. "There. First mystery."

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P001 / A PLACE TO START

The Blackwell Legacy

Edition considered: PC original game; current publisher patch must be recorded

Meet a reluctant New York medium and her sharp-tongued ghost partner in a compact mystery built around their developing relationship.

What you do. Talk with people, follow notebook leads, and connect names or clues while revisiting places in a supernatural investigation.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Names and notebook combinations take tracking; verify manual speech advance, and consider the suicide and bereavement themes.

Why it might click. A compact New York supernatural mystery joins a reluctant medium to a sardonic spirit guide. Conversations and notebook connections make discovery feel personal; the developing partnership offers more reason to continue than simply clearing another puzzle.

The full catch. Notebook combinations, returning to locations, and remembering names remain real work. Suicide and bereavement are central. Reviews report no timed or dexterity challenges, but this is not a complete-path playtest. Current desktop patches offer manual speech advance through a Ctrl+P toggle; verify it waits.

Try this first. Set manual speech advance if you want it, with help if useful. Try one conversation and one notebook lead, then decide whether these two people are company worth keeping.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P001 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

The Blackwell Legacy

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Ghost Delegation Has Arrived

I reserved a seat for Joey Mallone because Blackwell had a ghost partner and our summit had an attendance minimum. One more delegate could keep the hotel from charging for empty chairs. Rae lifted his name card. “Does he want chips?” “He transcends appetite.” Tank reached around her. “Then he transcends these.”

Kit was trying to hang her entrance banner without covering the screen. Her reading glasses slid down her nose. She pushed them up, looked at Joey’s chair, and asked whether an invisible guest also needed an entrance song.

“Something haunting,” I said. Mercedes played three notes from the invoice notification on my phone. The whole fucking room recognized it.

Our Rosa watched the medium get another unwanted responsibility. “That’s my supernatural power too.” She handed me the catering form. I tried passing it to the ghost delegation.

Rae sat in Joey’s empty chair and held the screen steady for Kit. Tank kept the chips. Nigga, even the dead were organizing more effectively than me.

Aiden’s verdict. The ghost partnership may earn your curiosity; follow the plain notes first. At our summit, the invisible delegate has already lost both his vote and his snacks.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher premise and developer Ctrl+P patch notice; timing description is a secondary review, not current complete-path testing. PC original only.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/80330/>

Source 2: <https://steamcommunity.com/app/80330/allnews/>

Source 3: <https://www.keengamer.com/articles/reviews/the-blackwell-legacy-review/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P002 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The Darkside Detective

Edition considered: PC first game; current accessibility build must be recorded

Investigate small, absurd paranormal cases with a recurring comic detective partnership, using static scenes that keep the focus on dialogue and objects.

What you do. Inspect objects, read conversations, and try using inventory items on the scene or on one another to advance a case.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Inventory dragging, small hotspots, and pipe or tile puzzles need checking even though timed input is not declared.

Why it might click. Comic paranormal investigations offer a recurring detective partnership and short case boundaries. Static scenes let attention settle on objects, dialogue, and absurd situations rather than keeping an avatar and camera moving together.

The full catch. Current Steam metadata declares play without timed input. That does not mean hold-free: PC reviews describe dragging inventory items onto objects or other items. Pipe and tile puzzles also appear. Text reading and small hotspots deserve an actual check before treating this as comfortable.

Try this first. Begin the first case, inspect one object, and test one inventory drag. Check that text advance and the save/exit route feel understandable before continuing.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P002 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

The Darkside Detective

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Haunting Has a Lighting Rider

Kit wanted blue light for her entrance. Rae wanted enough ordinary light to find the signing table. I promised both and pressed the button marked ATMOSPHERE.

The ballroom went purple. A motor groaned behind the curtain. Tank said, “Nigga, your atmosphere sounds like it owes money.”

We had The Darkside Detective on a monitor, which encouraged me to identify the groan as a paranormal case. Mika opened the curtain. My rented revolving platform was trying to turn beneath a refrigerator.

“That isn't a ghost,” they said. “That's your champagne presentation.” I said presentations required mystery. Rae unplugged it before the mystery required a fire report.

Kit found a separate lamp and aimed it at the table. Then she restored her blue entrance light. Two useful decisions, neither of which required me to say haunting again.

Remy tried the microphone. “Spirits are high.” Velvet closed her eyes. “Baby, save something for the people who aren't trapped here.” I paid the refrigerator's appearance fee.

Aiden's verdict. These little paranormal cases invite curiosity, with dragging still worth testing. Our electrical mystery ended when somebody stopped listening to my description and looked behind the curtain.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary Steam accessibility declarations inspected. Inventory dragging is documented by a PC review; no hold-free alternative was verified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/api/appdetails?appids=368390&l=english>

Source 2: <https://www.bigbossbattle.com/review-the-darkside-detective/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P003 / A PLACE TO START

Phoenix Wright: Ace Attorney Trilogy

Edition considered: 2019 PC compilation; post-November 2025 update scope

Meet theatrical witnesses and recurring friends in courtroom mysteries where matching a statement to evidence can produce a satisfying breakthrough.

What you do. Read testimony, consult the Court Record, and compare statements with evidence; the updated compilation also offers Story Mode assistance.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Reading and evidence menus are central; automatic text progression may feel rushed, and wrong evidence can incur penalties.

Why it might click. The original trilogy supplies memorable witnesses, recurring friendships, and theatrical courtroom mysteries. Comparing testimony with a piece of evidence can deliver a satisfying click of understanding; the story has room for comedy and emotional stakes.

The full catch. Reading and Court Record menus are central, and wrong evidence can incur penalties. Dramatic music may feel urgent even when the interface waits. The November 2025 update adds Story Mode and Auto-play; automatic text progression may itself feel rushed. Later evidence interactions still need checking.

Try this first. Use the updated 2019 compilation. Start The First Turnabout with manual text advance, compare one statement, and use Story Mode whenever enjoying the next scene matters more than solving it.

Aiden’s complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P003 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Phoenix Wright: Ace Attorney Trilogy

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / Objection, the Host Has Bought Another Entrance

Nia saw Phoenix Wright on the screen and asked why my hotel bill described a SECOND TRIUMPHAL ARRIVAL. I said the first triumph had gone well in rehearsal.

“You haven't arrived once,” Shawna said. “You've been here all afternoon.” “Emotionally, baby.” “Financially, too.”

Rae wanted the receipt entered into evidence. Kit objected because her entrance music had been charged to the same line. Suddenly the rival caucuses shared a fascinating concern about itemization.

I pointed at Nia. “You're a lawyer. Defend me.” She looked at the receipt. “I'm off duty, and the witness has written his confession in gold foil.”

Remy struck a small gong for order. Its handle came off in his hand. Velvet took the gong away and gave him a spoon. Nobody let me call a recess.

The verdict was simple: one entrance per actual arrival. Kit got her music separated from my nonsense. Rae saved a chair beside Nia. Nigga, the defense had plans after court.

Aiden's verdict. The courtroom ensemble can be wonderful company, with menus and evidence tracking understood. My summit's first ruling limits triumphal arrivals to occasions when somebody actually arrives.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Current Steam declares play without timed input; Capcom November 2025 notice confirms Story Mode for this 2019 trilogy. No hands-on audit of all cases or holds.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/787480/>

Source 2: <https://steamcommunity.com/app/787480/announcements/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P004 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Strange Horticulture

Edition considered: PC current release

Run a rain-soaked plant shop where curious customers, occult questions, and identifying unusual specimens gradually reveal a world beyond the counter.

What you do. Compare plants with the reference book, handle objects on the desk, and follow letters or map clues for further discoveries.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Cross-referencing and dragging need testing; wrong answers raise Rising Dread and can trigger a recovery puzzle.

Why it might click. A rain-soaked plant shop provides a recurring home base, curious customers, and an occult story. Identifying specimens connects looking closely with useful decisions, while letters and map clues gradually widen the world beyond the counter.

The full catch. Books, plants, labels, letters, and a map can create substantial cross-referencing. Desk objects use dragging; a developer patch added a double-click sticky-drag alternative, whose own double-click demand needs testing. Wrong answers raise Rising Dread and can lead to a recovery puzzle. Calm presentation is not simplicity.

Try this first. Identify one customer's plant with the reference book. Compare ordinary dragging with the documented sticky option before adding map exploration or several simultaneous questions to the desk.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P004 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Strange Horticulture

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Plant Shop Has a Catering Complaint

Strange Horticulture inspired me to label the centerpieces with mysterious Latin names. Rosa read one card and asked why I was serving sandwiches beside Something Possibly Fatal. “Atmosphere.” “Move your fucking atmosphere away from my bread.”

Rae wanted fresh mint for the water. Kit wanted the fern removed from her sightline to the stage. I said the plants were participants in the occult experience. Shawna asked whether the fern had paid a deposit.

Nia inspected my labels. Every scientific name was a cocktail. She turned over the nearest card. “This plant is apparently a Double Manhattan.”

Mercedes took the labels for song requests. Mika moved the tall centerpiece onto a low side table, where it promptly looked better. I pretended that had been my second design proposal.

Rae brought Nia a glass with actual mint. Nia thanked her without making a speech. I tried offering Shawna a botanical surprise. “If that means another fern in our suite, nigga, surprise somebody else.”

Aiden’s verdict. The plant shop’s close observation may appeal, while dragging and cross-referencing deserve a trial. Our centerpiece survived only after its mysterious identity stopped threatening the sandwiches.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher premise inspected; developer patch mirrored on SteamDB supports sticky dragging. No-customer-deadline observation is secondary, not full-path verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1574580/>

Source 2: <https://steamdb.info/patchnotes/8300183/>

Source 3: <https://www.gamesradar.com/have-you-tried-strange-horticulture/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
Niggas, lights on.	Niggas, mic check.	Niggas, take turns.	Niggas, dance later.	Niggas, read first.
Niggas, pick freely.	Niggas, no rush.	Niggas, sign here.	Niggas, stay petty.	Niggas, we’re good.

P005 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The Case of the Golden Idol

Edition considered: PC 2022 game with current Redux edition; not The Rise of the Golden Idol

Turn suspicious deaths into an unfolding conspiracy by linking the people, objects, and motives visible in carefully arranged crime scenes.

What you do. Inspect a scene, identify its people, and place words into deduction slots to build an explanation that fits the evidence.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Later cases accumulate names and possible words; check placement controls, hints, text size, and comfort with murder imagery.

Why it might click. Static scenes of suspicious deaths become a larger conspiracy as names, objects, and motives connect. The reward is constructing an explanation that fits the evidence, with visual detail and social relationships doing much of the storytelling.

The full catch. Later cases add many names, roles, and possible words. Murder imagery is deliberate, and the grotesque art may not be welcoming. This card concerns the original game with its current Redux edition, not Rise. Check exact word-placement, text size, and hint controls rather than assuming every release behaves identically.

Try this first. Study the first scene and identify the people before attempting its full explanation. Try moving one word into a deduction slot, then inspect the hint interface if curiosity has turned into bookkeeping.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P005 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

The Case of the Golden Idol

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Golden Idol Has My Chin

I unveiled the centerpiece statue while The Case of the Golden Idol filled the monitor. A bronze-looking man stood on a little plinth, one hand raised toward destiny.

Tank leaned close. “Nigga, that's you.” “An idealized statesman.” “They idealized your stomach.”

Kit found a red velvet rope around it and assumed something valuable had been stolen. Rae said something valuable had definitely disappeared from the budget. Nia asked whether the figure could hold the missing treaty pen.

I placed a pen in its raised hand. The hand bent forward. My idealized statesman now appeared to be demanding a gratuity from a fern.

Velvet examined the plinth. “It rotates?” “For the reveal.” “Put my spotlight on it.” She stepped onto the nearby floor mark and transformed my unveiling into a rehearsal for her number.

Mika let her finish before telling me the statue blocked a cable route. We moved it. Nigga, the first conspiracy in the room was everybody discovering a better use for my monument.

Aiden's verdict. Enjoy assembling a conspiracy if the names and deductions sound satisfying. Our golden idol's secret was a rental surcharge and a much better performer standing beside it.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher describes freely investigated freeze-frame scenes; current-edition announcements establish Redux. Drag/hold behavior and full completion were not playtested.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1677770/>

Source 2: <https://steamcommunity.com/app/1677770/allnews/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P006 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Syberia

Edition considered: 2002 PC original; not Syberia Remastered

Follow a lawyer through an unusual European world of mechanical wonders, where the journey gradually changes what she considers important.

What you do. Click to explore locations, speak with people, collect useful objects, and use inventory items while following Kate's journey.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The 2002 original has small hotspots, fixed camera cuts, inventory, and repeated travel; complete timing freedom is unverified.

Why it might click. The original Syberia follows a lawyer into an unusual European world of mechanical wonders and unfinished lives. Kate's changing sense of what matters gives the travel emotional momentum beyond collecting the next useful object.

The full catch. This is the 2002 PC original, not the remaster. Click movement removes a separate look control, but fixed camera cuts, small hotspots, dialogue topics, inventory, and repeated travel can still frustrate. The publisher walkthrough's late sections use ordinary interactions; that is not an exhaustive no-timer guarantee.

Try this first. Explore the opening hotel, speak with one person, and test the inventory and save route. Let one useful object establish whether the older interface is inviting before committing to a long journey.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P006 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Syberia

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Automaton Is in the Coat Room

Syberia's mechanical world made me regret nothing about hiring a clockwork-looking greeter. It stood beside registration with brass shoulders, a little hat, and one excellent prerecorded welcome.

Rae walked past it. "Welcome, distinguished chairman." She stopped. "No." I said the greeting was generic. "So is the refund request," she said.

Mika opened its panel while Kit examined the gear decorations. Most of them were glued on. The entire mechanical wonder was a speaker wearing an expensive coat.

Shawna pressed the next button. "Welcome, distinguished chairman," it said again, louder. Tank put a bread roll in its open hand. "Nigga needs something to do."

We found the actual welcome recording on my phone. Mercedes had made it that morning. Warm, brief, no chairman. I had forgotten to send it because I was choosing epaulettes.

Mika replaced the audio. Rae carried the greeter to the coat room, where it welcomed everyone perfectly. My mechanical empire advanced through a cable and an apology.

Aiden's verdict. The journey's mechanical wonders have their own charm; examine the original edition's practical catches. Our greeter improved dramatically when we replaced ceremonial nonsense with an actual welcome.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected original-game publisher description and seven-page official walkthrough, including late sequences. Original PC control scope only; no full playtest.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/46500/>

Source 2: <https://support.microids.com/fr/support/solutions/articles/23000009217-solutions-syberia-1-et-2>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P007 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Unavowed

Edition considered: PC release

Meet an urban-fantasy investigation team whose histories and different abilities make the companions themselves a reason to pursue another case.

What you do. Choose an origin, talk with companions, and use objects or companion abilities to investigate situations and work through puzzles.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Inventory and abilities add memory demands; later timing and holding requirements are not fully audited across every branch.

Why it might click. An urban-fantasy investigation puts companions, their histories, and their abilities at the center of puzzle solving. Origins and branching situations give the ensemble room to react differently, making the people a reason to explore the next case.

The full catch. Inventory plus companion abilities creates more to remember than a simple conversation game. Violence, possession, death, and strong language are substantial. Ordinary PC interaction is pointer-based, but urgent scenes and every branch's timing or holding demands have not been fully audited.

Try this first. Choose an origin because it sounds interesting, meet the opening companions, and try one interaction. Verify text waiting and pause on the actual edition before relying on the adventure's slower ordinary rhythm.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P007 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Unavowed

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / Everybody Brought a Different Kind of Trouble

Unavowed's companions had different histories and abilities. I announced that our coalition also required a specially selected team. Nia asked whether I meant the people already doing the work. “Exactly. I recognized their potential.” “After they carried your statue.”

Rae could fix the signing table's wobble. Kit knew where the spare lamps were. Mika had the floor manager's actual number. I offered charisma. Tank offered to carry charisma outside if it kept talking. Velvet wanted a team for her costume change, which sounded much more glamorous. I volunteered immediately. She handed me a garment steamer and pointed at the crease I had just made by leaning against her cape.

Shawna watched me concentrate. “Look at that. An ability.” I said I had several she knew intimately. “Keep one of them on the fabric, baby.”

By the time the crease vanished, Rae had fixed the table and Kit had found the missing pen cap. The team advanced. Its founder was still untangling a cord.

Aiden’s verdict. The companions may make the investigation worth learning, with branching input questions still open. My special ability currently involves keeping Velvet's cape away from a chair wheel.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary publisher premise and companion features inspected. PC interaction and content detail supported by review; zero timed inputs across branches remains unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/336140/>

Source 2: <https://gamecritics.com/gc-staff/unavowed-review/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P008 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Her Story

Edition considered: PC release

Follow words through live-action police interviews, letting a performance, contradiction, or unanswered question determine which part of the mystery you explore next.

What you do. Watch returned interview clips, type a promising search word, and compare what people say across the results you uncover.

Dialogue / text choices | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Typing and nonlinear recollection can be demanding; convenient hands-free video pausing has not been verified on desktop.

Why it might click. A live-action police interview mystery lets a noticed word become the next direction of exploration. Performance, contradiction, and interpretation supply the interest; there is no avatar or separate look camera between the player and the testimony.

The full catch. Typing, names, nonlinear clips, and remembering what a phrase referred to can be demanding. Convenient video pausing is unverified: player reports describe holding the slider to freeze a clip. Do not assume search-at-your-own-pace means hands-free pause during playback. Crime and relationship material is mature.

Try this first. On desktop, watch one returned clip, test how it stops or replays, and follow one promising word. Keep a short question nearby only if it helps preserve the thread.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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Niggas, we're good.

P008 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Her Story

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / Her Testimony Has a Better Search Term

Her Story made everyone interested in searching a statement by one revealing word. I suggested we search my welcome video for vision. Porsche searched for refundable.

Nothing came up. Tank whispered, “Nigga, that's the mystery.”

The missing treaty had last appeared in a clip I recorded beside the registration desk. We watched me lift a folder, praise my own foresight, then hand it off without looking. The recipient was outside the frame.

Kit asked for the next clip. I had recorded my shoes instead. Rae admired the sheer consistency of a man documenting everything except useful information.

Nia noticed a silver cuff at the edge of the image. Velvet held up both wrists. “These are gold, counselor. Don't implicate affordable jewelry in my affairs.”

Shawna found a later photograph. Mika had the folder, but the photograph didn't show where it went next. I proposed another speech to establish context. Six people said no with strikingly different levels of affection.

Aiden’s verdict. The interview search can reward a noticed detail; typing and video control deserve a check. My footage contributed one cuff, two shoes, and several minutes nobody can recover.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary publisher describes search/watch loop. Pause limitation is dated secondary user evidence, not verified current behavior; Telling Lies controls must not be substituted.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/368370/>

Source 2: <https://steamcommunity.com/app/368370/discussions/0/530645446312998268/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P009 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The Excavation of Hob's Barrow

Edition considered: PC release

Explore Victorian folk horror through a suspicious village, bleak moors, and an antiquarian's investigation of a burial mound with unsettling implications.

What you do. Visit the opening village, speak with people, examine clues, and use inventory objects while following the antiquarian's investigation.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Horror and sudden audiovisual moments may feel pressuring; PC inventory dragging and later clue chains need checking.

Why it might click. Victorian folk horror gives its investigation a strong sense of place: moors, suspicious villagers, an antiquarian, and a burial mound. For someone who enjoys unease, the slow accumulation of wrongness may be as engaging as solving the inventory puzzles.

The full catch. Bleak horror, violence, and abrupt audiovisual moments can create pressure without a reflex timer. PC descriptions include inventory dragging. A Switch accessibility assessment reports low pressure and optional holds, but that does not prove hold-free PC play. Later puzzle chains still require remembering information.

Try this first. Try the opening village and one conversation. Test an inventory action and text advance on the exact edition; leave if the atmosphere itself is unpleasant, even if the controls behave perfectly.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P009 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

The Excavation of Hob's Barrow

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Burial Mound Is a Coat Pile

Hob's Barrow gave our investigation a moody turn. I found a suspicious mound behind the stage and told Rae we might be dealing with a deliberately concealed chamber.

She lifted a sleeve. "We're dealing with coats." "People conceal things in coats." "Usually their arms, nigga."

Kit insisted one coat contained her missing glasses. They were on her head. She removed them, thanked Rae very quietly, and then accused me of burying her entrance banner beneath the mound.

The banner was there. So was a pair of shoes, three abandoned welcome bags, and Remy's little crown. He emerged from rehearsal demanding to know why the monarchy had been interred.

Velvet put the crown on him crooked. "Historical accuracy." Remy bowed, knocked the banner loose, and revealed the hotel map we'd been trying to find.

I claimed the excavation as a success. Rosa handed me the coats. "Then carry your findings to the fucking coat room." Archaeology had developed a surprisingly personal labor requirement.

Aiden's verdict. Folk horror has a distinct appeal when unease is welcome; heed its emotional and input catches. Our excavation recovered a map and made the narrator useful for once.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher horror premise inspected. Switch low-pressure panel and PC drag description are secondary and edition-specific; no blanket control guarantee.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1182310/>

Source 2: <https://www.nintendolife.com/reviews/switch-eshop/the-excavation-of-hobs-barrow>

Source 3: https://as.com/meristation/2022/09/28/analysis/1664375021_208084.html

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P010 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Pentiment

Edition considered: PC release

Investigate a richly drawn historical community where art, faith, class, and personal loyalties give conversations consequences that unfold over years.

What you do. Walk between people, read conversations, and choose which leads or activities to pursue as the investigation develops around the community.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Reading and relationships accumulate; activities advance investigation time, and walking may require holding even without timed inputs.

Why it might click. A richly drawn historical community makes art, class, faith, and personal loyalties part of the investigation. People and consequences unfold over years, offering conversation and interpretation rather than a constant demand for quick physical reactions.

The full catch. Developer accessibility notes state there are no timed inputs or QTEs. Investigation time still advances through chosen activities, which creates decision pressure. Reading is extensive, movement may require holding, and names and relationships accumulate. Narration support differs by platform; do not assume every line is spoken.

Try this first. Try walking and one early conversation with readable text settings. Notice whether choosing a lead feels intriguing or burdensome before promising yourself an entire investigation or an optimal outcome.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P010 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Pentiment

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Illuminated Agenda Costs Extra

Pentiment's historical art prompted me to order an illuminated agenda. Gold initials, curling vines, a drawing of the summit founder in a position of modest authority.

Kit unfolded it. "That's a throne." "Modest for a throne."

Rae wanted to know when the games started. The agenda began with a poem about my generosity. Nia traced a beautiful vine across the paper until it ended at a blank space where the start time should have been.

Mika wrote the time in pencil. I protested that the calligrapher had a vision. "So do the caterers," they said. "It involves leaving before breakfast."

Mercedes liked the border and asked whether she could use it around her set list. Velvet requested the tiny portrait for a joke during her number. Suddenly my commission had three practical uses, none involving the poem.

Shawna folded the agenda into her bag. "I'm keeping this." I smiled. "Sentimental?" "Evidence. Nigga, the next romantic weekend is a beach and two towels."

Aiden's verdict. The historical community rewards sustained attention, with reading and activity choices carrying weight. Our illuminated agenda became useful at the precise moment somebody wrote a time on it.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected developer accessibility notes and first-hand interview on activity-based investigation time. Turn pacing differs from decision pressure; actual movement setup untested.

Source 1: <https://pentiment.obsidian.net/>

Source 2: <https://www.mmorpg.com/interviews/the-rpg-files-building-obsidians-pentiment-interview-with-game-director-josh-sawyer-2000126821>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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The First War Had a Jacket and the Second Had a Default Setting

June put a photograph on the table during the break. Four women stood outside the Blue Comet in 1967, grinning beside a car whose hood occupied most of the street. Dez touched the corner carefully. June pointed at her own shoulders.

“My jacket.”

“Our jacket,” Dez said. Rae made a low appreciative sound. Nia pulled up a chair. I reached for a microphone. Shawna took it out of my hand before anybody needed to explain why two elderly women discussing a photograph didn't require amplification.

June had bought the jacket with money she'd saved. Dez had borrowed it, altered it, and developed a theory of ownership based on how often people complimented her in it. At one point she'd returned something she described as equivalent. “It was brown,” Dez said. “So was the jacket.” June stared at her. “Aiden, this nigga returned a cardigan.” Tank nearly inhaled an olive. Kit sat down so quickly her glasses slid into her lap.

Dez insisted the cardigan had pockets. June said pockets weren't restitution. Remy wanted to know whether this dispute had inspired the original peace agreement. June said the agreement came after somebody interrupted her jukebox song. Dez said June remembered paying for the record and forgot who'd had the taste to select it. Both claimed the other had left the agreement unsigned.

Kit studied the photograph. “I thought the first rivalry was supposed to explain ours.”

June looked at her. “Which one is ours?”

Kit glanced between herself and Rae, then at the invitation. The design had helped her reach the wrong answer. White butch on one side, Black stud on the other, although my words had not stated it quite that plainly. I had put the faces in separate colored panels and trusted implication to perform the labor I couldn't defend aloud. June, a Black butch sitting directly between them, had become a very expensive problem for my layout.

“I know those aren't mutually exclusive categories,” Kit said. “I didn't invent his fucking invitation.”

“No,” Rae said. “But when he called you the butch representative, you took the good chair.”

Kit's jaw shifted. I recognized the look: a person finding one true detail inside an accusation and desperately wanting to negotiate the rest before acknowledging it. I had worn that look through three vehicle inspections. “I took the chair because I was carrying the music folder. You could have asked for it.”

“Why did I have to ask you?”

The room got quiet in a different way. Not reverent. Uncomfortable. My instinct was to buy something that made a noise. Shawna put her hand on my wrist without looking at me.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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Kit said she hadn't felt particularly powerful arriving at an event where the host expected her to be a mascot. At the library she still heard people soften their voices before asking whether she worked in maintenance. She knew what it was to be stared at, to have a woman pull her child closer, to see her clothes become somebody else's public question. "So when you say I just get to be the default, I don't know where that person lives. I'd like her rent."

Rae let her finish. "I'm not saying nobody does shit to you. I'm saying the hotel guy asked you where you wanted the lamp. He asked me which door the contractors were using. Same shoes, same table, same invitation in my hand."

Kit looked toward the corridor. She'd been present for that exchange. "I thought he meant because you were fixing it."

"He hadn't seen me fix anything." Rae wasn't loud. That made it harder for me to hope the moment would dissolve into ordinary party noise. "You don't have to invent my experience out of yours before it counts."

June tapped the photograph. "And don't make me disappear so the argument fits two columns. I've been a Black butch longer than either of y'all has been deciding what to call this seating arrangement."

Dez smiled. "She was a difficult Black butch before breakfast too." June nudged her knee. The laugh loosened the room without cancelling anything that had been said.

I tried explaining that I wanted the invitation to feel bold. Rae turned it over. "Bold for whom, nigga? You get a funny war. I get assigned a whole personality before I even complain about the crackers."

That landed because she had complained about the crackers. I had treated the complaint as perfect character confirmation: of course my stud delegate arrived ready to inspect the room. The fact was less convenient. Rae was a mechanic, liked things that worked, and had been served terrible crackers. I had converted three ordinary facts into a costume that supposedly explained her.

"Stud is a word I learned from Black women who made room for me," Rae said. "It means something to me. It isn't a menu where you order confidence, tools, and whatever voice you think goes with them." She paused. "And yes, I brought tools. I'm not giving them back just to defeat your symbolism."

Kit laughed once, then stopped trying to make Rae laugh on her behalf. "I liked being introduced without having to explain myself," she said. "That's the part I don't want to admit. You said butch like the room would know what to do with me, and I liked it. I didn't ask who you were making explain the rest."

Rae nodded. It wasn't absolution. Kit didn't demand any. She took off the little ribbon I'd pinned to her chair and laid it on the table. Then she asked whether Rae actually wanted that chair. "No. I want the one beside Nia." Rae realized she'd said it plainly and reached for her water too quickly. Nia looked delighted and had the decency to examine her glass instead of conducting a public hearing.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
Niggas, lights on.	Niggas, mic check.	Niggas, take turns.	Niggas, dance later.	Niggas, read first.
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Remy leaned back. “Can I put in one request? Don't turn masculinity into a staircase with me at the top because I'm a man.” He adjusted his tiny crown. “I spent forty minutes trying to glue this straight. Nobody should be aspiring upward into this particular crisis.”

Velvet straightened it with two fingers. “There, your majesty. Social progress.”

He smiled. “Somebody sees Rae, then Kit, then me, and wants one explanation for all of us. It saves them asking a person anything. I'm a trans man. My drag king is a performance. Those aren't interchangeable with being a butch woman, and being a man doesn't make me better at the microphone.”

“Nothing could,” Velvet said tenderly. He kissed her hand in theatrical gratitude for the review.

Kit looked at Rae's jacket. “For the record, that shoulder line is beautiful.” Rae smiled. “Your suit too. You look like you know exactly which song you want.” Kit sat a little taller. She liked her shape in those clothes; Rae liked hers. No correction was required. June watched them with satisfaction. “Looking good is allowed to be part of the politics, babies. Otherwise Dez owes me fifty-nine years of evidence for why she kept borrowing the damn jacket.”

Kit admitted she sometimes felt pushed to prove her masculinity by being unbothered. Don't ask for help. Don't enjoy the wrong song. Don't look too excited when somebody pretty notices you. “I've had gay male friends understand the performance part beautifully, and one tell me I was basically a junior version of him. I told him he couldn't afford my subscription.”

Rae said her friendships with men weren't one category either. One friend asked before helping with her bike; another assumed every repair was an audition for a masculinity contest. “I like the first nigga. The second can hold the flashlight if he learns to shut up.” She looked at Nia, then back. “And I don't want a woman to pick me because she thinks she's bought the reliable man package without a man in it.”

Nia put her glass down. “Good. I'm terrible at assembling packages. I like that you got excited explaining the brakes. You stopped checking whether everybody else was impressed.” Rae's face changed. Mine would have too. It was an intimate observation, and Nia offered it without making either of them a public symbol.

Shawna said she loved a man who sometimes confused being wanted with being required to run everything. I looked at her. “Baby.” “I'm speaking from the archive.” She squeezed my wrist. “Your tender parts aren't a leak in your authority, Aiden. Sometimes they're the only parts listening.”

I had a joke ready and let it go. That cost nothing and felt expensive.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
Niggas, lights on.	Niggas, mic check.	Niggas, take turns.	Niggas, dance later.	Niggas, read first.
Niggas, pick freely.	Niggas, no rush.	Niggas, sign here.	Niggas, stay petty.	Niggas, we're good.

Kit wanted to know what happened next. Not to the world; to our invitation, to the chairs, to the evening. Rae said she wanted the title left ridiculous if everyone remembered it wasn't a map of human beings. Kit could keep her entrance light. Rae could sit beside Nia. June could exist without becoming a footnote that repaired my race chart. The disagreement would not vanish because I found better paper.

I crossed out REPRESENTATIVE on the place cards. People could introduce themselves, and the caucuses could overlap. Kit kept her ribbon for the lamp. June kept the photograph. Dez kept the jacket, under protest. Rosa announced food, and nobody converted dinner into a reward for reaching ideological completion.

Shawna handed me the microphone at last. "One sentence." I looked at the room. "The good crackers are over there." Rae laughed first. Nigga, I had finally made an announcement I could substantiate.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
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P011 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Old Skies

Edition considered: PC release

Travel through seven historical settings with a time agent and voiced companions, exploring regret and the consequences of changing past events.

What you do. Meet the first assignment, examine objects, follow characters' motives, and work through puzzles involving cause and effect across time.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Death and retry are explicit features; temporal connections increase memory demands, and later input requirements still need checking.

Why it might click. A time agent's work provides seven historical settings and travelers with different motives. Temporal puzzles and a voiced ensemble connect the speculative premise to questions about regret, curiosity, and the consequences of changing what already happened.

The full catch. The publisher explicitly says the player can die and try again. That is a meaningful failure-state warning, not proof of harmless pacing. Temporal cause and effect can increase memory demands, and later timing, dragging, and dialogue advance need an edition-specific check. Some historical settings carry serious emotional weight.

Try this first. Meet Fia and inspect the first assignment before promising a complete excursion. Test ordinary object interaction and the pause/save route; treat any stressful sequence as a reason to reconsider, not an examination to pass.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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P011 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Old Skies

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Time Agent Wants Yesterday's Rate

Old Skies put time travel within professional reach. I asked Nia whether a contract could be renegotiated yesterday. She said yesterday I should have read it.

“Nigga, that's what I'm proposing.” “You're proposing a time machine because you rented six chandeliers.”

Mika loved the chandeliers. This surprised everyone until they arranged three over the dance floor and admitted the room looked spectacular. Kit wanted the other three behind her karaoke entrance. Rae pointed at the empty signing table. “Could one future include a lamp here?” Nia brought her a lamp. She also brought a chair and stayed in it, which seemed like a promising use of the present. Shawna asked what I would change if we could travel backward. I said I would meet her sooner. She softened. Then I added that we could have booked the room before the weekend surcharge.

Her look traveled several years into my future. “Start over,” she said. I did, using fewer dates and absolutely no pricing information.

Aiden’s verdict. The time-travel ensemble offers motives worth following, while death and retry remain real features. My attempt to revise history has been returned for a more romantic second draft.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher description: time-agent premise, historical eras, temporal puzzles, and retryable death. No declared absence of timed sequences established.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1346360/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
Niggas, lights on.	Niggas, mic check.	Niggas, take turns.	Niggas, dance later.	Niggas, read first.
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P012 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Primordia

Edition considered: PC release

Explore a decaying post-human world with a robot partnership whose banter and discoveries connect a theft to larger questions of belief and independence.

What you do. Spend time with the two robots, examine objects, and connect environmental details or inventory items to solve their immediate problems.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Puzzle connections and revisiting details take attention; the inspected source does not establish timer-free or hold-free play.

Why it might click. A robot partnership explores a post-human landscape and a city whose history changes the meaning of the initial theft. Mechanical decay, belief, independence, and companion banter make its world distinctive rather than merely another collection of locked doors.

The full catch. Environmental and inventory puzzles still ask for connections and returning to details. Optional puzzles exist, but optional extras do not make the main path effortless. The inspected storefront does not certify zero timers, no holds, or a particular text-wait setting; those remain checks, not benefits to assume.

Try this first. Spend an opening scene with Horatio and Crispin. Try examining one object and following one concrete problem, then decide whether the world's mood and puzzle language invite another visit.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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P012 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Primordia

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Robot Has Applied for Independence

Primordia's robot partnership had me considering a future without the hotel manager. Mika pointed out that most hotel problems in our room originated with a human called Aiden.

I directed attention to my electronic welcome podium. Its screen read UPDATE REQUIRED. Tank said, "Nigga, even your furniture wants a new host."

Rae opened the little cupboard beneath it and found six charging cables, all for something else. Remy tried speaking through its built-in microphone. The podium answered with a piercing squeal.

Velvet took his arm. "Come sing with the living, baby." He went immediately, carrying his victory fanfare on a tiny keyboard. A machine had lost a romantic man to a better sound system.

Kit fetched a handwritten sign from registration. Clear lettering, correct room, actual times. She propped it against the dead screen and reclaimed her lamp.

I asked whether the podium could remain as a symbol. Rosa set a water pitcher on it. "Now it symbolizes water." The post-human future had an unexpectedly sensible refreshment policy.

Aiden's verdict. The robot world's personality may be the draw, with puzzle and input uncertainties intact. Our technological monument has found a durable career supporting a pitcher of ordinary water.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected exact-game publisher description for robots, stolen core, Metropol and optional puzzles. Control and complete-path timing guarantees were not found in that record.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/227000/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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P013 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Strangeland

Edition considered: PC release

Enter a surreal carnival where strange inhabitants and symbolic puzzles explore identity and grief, with optional in-character hints to help interpretation.

What you do. Talk with inhabitants, interpret the surroundings, and investigate puzzle solutions; locate the optional hint system when you want help.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Suicide imagery, repeated death, and grotesque horror are central; alternative solutions do not prove a fully reaction-free route.

Why it might click. A surreal carnival turns identity, grief, and interpretation into an adventure's setting and puzzles. The publisher describes different solutions and meanings, a voiced cast, and an optional in-character hint system, giving the strange inhabitants more purpose than decoration.

The full catch. Suicide imagery, repeated death, grotesque bodies, and horror are central. Alternative puzzle solutions do not establish a fully reaction-free path; the publisher itself contrasts a shooting approach with another solution. Inventory reasoning and symbolic interpretation can also be substantial. Verify actual interaction before relying on a particular route.

Try this first. Read the premise and look at the opening atmosphere before beginning an investigation. If that is appealing, try one conversation and locate the optional hint system; no need to demonstrate tolerance for distressing imagery.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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Niggas, lights on.

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Niggas, we're good.

P013 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Strangeland

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Carnival Charges by the Reflection

The carnival in Strangeland made me reveal a surprise: a funhouse mirror wall beside the registration table. I expected wonder. Shawna saw eight versions of my suit and sighed.

“Nigga, one of you already takes up the evening.”

Velvet loved the tall mirror. It made her headpiece look six feet high. Remy preferred the broad one and struck a kingly pose. Neither asked me to explain the symbolism, a failure I tried correcting anyway.

Rae walked behind the mirrors to check whether the treaty folder had fallen there. She found the missing tray of good crackers. Tank had created a private refreshment alcove.

“That wasn't hidden,” he said. “It was intimate.” Kit held up my original party invitation. The same word was printed on the front. Nigga, my influence had become a public health concern.

We moved the crackers into the room. Velvet kept one mirror for her costume check. I stood before the narrowest reflection and told Shawna I still had it. “Then carry it upstairs later,” she said.

Aiden’s verdict. The surreal carnival suits a taste for disturbing material; its serious themes deserve the warning above. Our mirror maze concealed crackers and an unforgivably flattering version of me.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher description explicitly covers nightmare imagery, multiple solutions and hints. No universal timing or hold exemption inferred from those alternatives.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1369520/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
Niggas, lights on.	Niggas, mic check.	Niggas, take turns.	Niggas, dance later.	Niggas, read first.
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P014 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Shardlight

Edition considered: PC release

Follow Amy through a post-apocalyptic investigation where inequality, loyalty, and a search for a cure give her difficult questions personal stakes.

What you do. Speak with people, follow a stated task, and use inventory objects or clues or clues to advance Amy's wider investigation through the setting.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Disease, hunger, and coercion make the story emotionally heavy; complete timing, holding, and dialogue-wait behavior remain unverified.

Why it might click. Amy's investigation gives an oppressive post-apocalyptic world a personal point of entry. The premise puts inequality, loyalty, and the search for a cure into the story, offering a protagonist with a concrete reason to keep asking difficult questions.

The full catch. Disease, hunger, death, and coercive government are explicit parts of the setting. They can make the experience emotionally heavy even during quiet interaction. Adventure puzzles bring inventory and clue demands. The source inspected here does not establish all-path timing, holding, or dialogue-wait behavior; those require a specific check.

Try this first. Try the opening conversation and one stated task only if the setting appeals. Test an inventory interaction and find save/quit before taking on the wider investigation or its darker consequences.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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Niggas, mic check.

Niggas, take turns.

Niggas, dance later.

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Niggas, stay petty.

Niggas, we're good.

P014 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Shardlight

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Ration Coupon Is for the Good Olives

Shardlight's divided world prompted an unfortunate comparison with my VIP snack table. Rae held up two bowls: good olives behind the rope, damp pretzels outside it.

“Who's VIP?” she asked. I named several sponsors. “Can they repair the signing table?” “Probably not.” “Then they're eating pretzels.”

Rosa had not approved the separation. A sponsor had moved the olives beside his banner while she was checking the kitchen. She took the entire bowl back without breaking conversation with the server.

I tried offering the sponsor a symbolic privilege. Mercedes suggested he could symbolically pay the musician. Velvet said she supported that tradition wholeheartedly.

Rae distributed the olives, saving a small dish for Nia. Nia looked pleased until Rae admitted she needed a witness that Tank had already taken three portions. Tank disputed the count but accepted the olives as evidence.

I removed the velvet rope. It snagged my jacket button. The hierarchy collapsed slowly, with me bent over trying to free my own ass from it.

Aiden’s verdict. The story's inequality and loyalties offer substantial material, with disease and coercion central. Our snack dispute ended with shared olives and a host physically caught in his own hierarchy.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact publisher premise inspected, including deprivation and vaccine lottery. Pointer-adventure classification is editorial; no complete-path control verification claimed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/336130/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
Niggas, lights on.	Niggas, mic check.	Niggas, take turns.	Niggas, dance later.	Niggas, read first.
Niggas, pick freely.	Niggas, no rush.	Niggas, sign here.	Niggas, stay petty.	Niggas, we're good.

P015 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Technobabylon

Edition considered: PC release

Discover a cyberpunk society through interwoven perspectives, where a police conspiracy and virtual experiences become questions of personal loyalty and choice.

What you do. Follow an opening protagonist's objective, read conversations, and connect inventory solutions with the developing investigation across different character perspectives.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Three protagonists, unfamiliar terms, and layered motives demand tracking; later confrontations and held inputs have not been fully checked.

Why it might click. Interwoven perspectives bring a cyberpunk city's systems down to individual choices and loyalties. A police conspiracy, virtual experience, and complicated personal stakes can supply a rich story for someone who enjoys gradually discovering how a speculative society works.

The full catch. Three protagonists, unfamiliar terms, inventory solutions, and layered motives increase the amount to track. The publisher warns of mature themes and violence. Point-and-click presentation does not establish that every later confrontation waits indefinitely, nor that every interaction avoids holds; the inspected source leaves those questions open.

Try this first. Follow one opening character and one immediate objective. Check text advance, ordinary interaction, and saving before deciding whether learning this future feels interesting rather than like another system to administer.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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Niggas, mic check.

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Niggas, stay petty.

Niggas, we're good.

P015 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Technobabylon

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Smart Ballroom Knows Too Much

Technobabylon put a connected city on the screen just as the ballroom assistant announced, “Aiden's private strawberries are ready.” The microphone was still live.

Shawna smiled very slowly. “Your smart room's a messy bitch.”

Nia asked Mika to mute the announcements. Mika was busy trying to keep the lighting from following my phone into the men's room. Every time I moved, the chandelier nearest me brightened.

“VIP tracking,” I explained. Kit walked away holding my phone. The light followed her. She stood on her entrance mark, delighted. “Finally, a useful patron.”

Rae found a printed control card beside the tablet. She passed it to Mika, who separated the music controls from my location. The room stopped worshipping my trousers.

Mercedes asked whether the system had also recorded her rehearsal. It hadn't; Porsche had the independent recorder exactly where she wanted it. One person had planned for the future. The rest of us were listening to the hotel repeat that my strawberries were getting warm.

Aiden’s verdict. The cyberpunk perspectives reward interest in complicated systems and motives. At our summit, the smartest person kept her recording separate from the room announcing my private dessert plans.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher account of three protagonists, Central, Trance, conspiracy and mature content. Exact late-game input demands remain unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/307580/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
Niggas, lights on.	Niggas, mic check.	Niggas, take turns.	Niggas, dance later.	Niggas, read first.
Niggas, pick freely.	Niggas, no rush.	Niggas, sign here.	Niggas, stay petty.	Niggas, we're good.

P016 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Blackwell Unbound

Edition considered: PC release

Meet an earlier human partner for Joey in period New York, where a ghostly musician and separate incidents suggest a contained supernatural mystery.

What you do. Follow Lauren and Joey through conversations and clue connections, pursuing an opening lead across the living and the dead.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Names and clues need tracking; do not assume this title shares another Blackwell game's speech controls or timing assurance.

Why it might click. An earlier Blackwell investigation changes the central human partner while retaining Joey's sardonic presence. Period New York, a ghostly musician, and apparently separate incidents provide a contained supernatural mystery with a different emotional texture from Legacy.

The full catch. Clues, names, dialogue topics, and switching attention between the living and the dead can still require tracking. This title's publisher record does not certify the same manual-speech patch behavior as another Blackwell game. Do not transfer Legacy's review-based timing assurance or Ctrl+P setup without checking this edition.

Try this first. Meet Lauren and Joey, listen to the first lead, and inspect the actual text and interaction settings. Continue because their relationship interests you, not because a series order has become another obligation.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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Niggas, mic check.

Niggas, take turns.

Niggas, dance later.

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Niggas, sign here.

Niggas, stay petty.

Niggas, we're good.

P016 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Blackwell Unbound

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Ghost Musician Has a Better Rider

Blackwell Unbound had a ghostly musician. Mercedes wondered aloud whether death at least ended arguments about soundcheck. Velvet said promoters would probably try paying in exposure across the veil.

Remy approached the microphone. “I’ve got a haunting number.” “You’ve got three puns and a keyboard,” Velvet said. “Show me the number.”

He played a little romantic fanfare, surprisingly gentle. Nia stopped reviewing the registration slips. Rae stopped pretending she hadn’t been listening. I saw an opportunity to introduce myself as patron of the arts.

Shawna caught my sleeve. “Let the man finish, nigga.”

Kit wanted the same warm spotlight for her entrance. Remy offered to share it if she stopped calling his keyboard a toy. She apologized to the keyboard first, which he accepted as sufficient diplomatic progress.

Mercedes marked a spot for him beside her piano. The ghost musician onscreen had company in spirit. I had company in person, specifically my wife standing on my foot whenever I inhaled like a man preparing a speech.

Aiden’s verdict. Period New York and the earlier partnership give this mystery its own flavor. Our living musicians have negotiated one shared spotlight and a temporary ban on my introductions.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher description establishes Lauren, Joey, 1973 and connected incidents. Input settings and no-timer claims are not inherited from other series entries.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/80340/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
Niggas, lights on.	Niggas, mic check.	Niggas, take turns.	Niggas, dance later.	Niggas, read first.
Niggas, pick freely.	Niggas, no rush.	Niggas, sign here.	Niggas, stay petty.	Niggas, we’re good.

P017 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Blackwell Convergence

Edition considered: PC release

Return to Rosa and Joey for a city mystery linking apparently separate lives through settings shaped by art, film, and finance.

What you do. Explore an opening location, speak with people, use inventory objects, and connect leads through the established pair's investigation in the city.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Earlier character history adds context; inventory reasoning remains work, and this edition's timing and dialogue controls need checking.

Why it might click. Rosa and Joey return to a city mystery whose apparently separate people and locations conceal a larger connection. Familiar characters can make another investigation attractive after an earlier entry, while the art, film, and finance setting gives it a specific flavor.

The full catch. This is a later series entry, so character history and supernatural rules add context to the clues. Inventory and conversational deductions remain work. The inspected publisher description establishes the premise, not a guarantee about timed scenes, held inputs, or current dialogue controls on every version.

Try this first. If the partnership already appeals, investigate one opening location and one lead. Check text waiting and item use on this installation rather than relying on remembered settings from a different Blackwell title.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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Niggas, snacks here.

Niggas, receipts ready.

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Niggas, mic check.

Niggas, take turns.

Niggas, dance later.

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Niggas, sign here.

Niggas, stay petty.

Niggas, we're good.

P017 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Blackwell Convergence

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Film Premiere Is a Ten-Second Clip

Blackwell Convergence brought art and film into the evening, which reminded Porsche she had footage of my first attempt to unveil the summit banner. I requested a private screening. She connected it to the biggest monitor. “Very private. Only this room.”

Onscreen I pulled the cord with magnificent confidence. The banner rolled halfway down, stopped at BUTCHES VERSUS, and dropped a plastic laurel wreath onto my head. Kit laughed so hard she misplaced her glasses again.

Rae replayed the moment my face changed. “That’s when the budget left his body.” Nia wanted a copy for strictly nonprofessional reasons.

I said the clip had been taken out of context. Shawna asked whether the missing context made me better at cords. Mercedes supplied live suspense music for the replay.

Mika finally unplugged the monitor because people were gathering in the doorway. They saved the clip first. Nigga, my coalition now possessed a shared cultural artifact, and I was wearing the fucker in high definition.

Aiden’s verdict. The linked city mystery may reward a returning fan, with its own controls still needing inspection. Our summit’s first film festival has one entry and an extremely unwilling star.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher premise inspected for connected film, office, artist and investor story. Later-series burden is editorial judgment; control guarantees remain unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/80350/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
Niggas, lights on.	Niggas, mic check.	Niggas, take turns.	Niggas, dance later.	Niggas, read first.
Niggas, pick freely.	Niggas, no rush.	Niggas, sign here.	Niggas, stay petty.	Niggas, we’re good.

P018 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Blackwell Deception

Edition considered: PC release

Join Rosa and Joey in an investigation of fraudulent psychics, personal secrets, and exploitation that also reaches into Joey's buried history.

What you do. Follow conversations and city leads, connect clues, and use the established partnership to investigate people claiming contact with the supernatural.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Death and manipulation are central; accumulated relationships add memory demands, and current input behavior needs its own check.

Why it might click. A mystery about fraudulent psychics lets an established supernatural partnership investigate both exploitation and personal secrets. Contrasting city settings and Joey's buried history may reward someone already curious about these characters rather than only the next puzzle solution.

The full catch. Death and manipulation of vulnerable hopes are central themes. Existing series relationships, dialogue, and clue connections can accumulate. The publisher premise does not establish an all-path absence of timed inputs or holds. Current text advance and inventory behavior should be checked independently of earlier Blackwell editions.

Try this first. Try one conversation and one lead if Rosa and Joey are welcome company. Notice the tone as well as the controls; interest in supernatural mysteries does not require enjoying every kind of darker subject.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

Niggas, pens out.

Niggas, chairs in.

Niggas, snacks here.

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Niggas, lights on.

Niggas, mic check.

Niggas, take turns.

Niggas, dance later.

Niggas, read first.

Niggas, pick freely.

Niggas, no rush.

Niggas, sign here.

Niggas, stay petty.

Niggas, we're good.

P018 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Blackwell Deception

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Psychic Predicts a Separate Invoice

A psychic in Blackwell Deception would have recognized our next guest: a sponsor's cousin offering aura readings beside Velvet's costume rack. She had already predicted that I was powerful and generous.

“Nigga, she read the deposit form,” Tank said.

Velvet asked whether the aura reader had permission to occupy her changing space. The woman said she sensed tension. “Excellent. Sense it from the corridor.”

Nia wanted her chair back. Rae wanted the good crackers removed from the consultation fee. The reader offered a coalition discount, which made her the third person that evening to treat my invitation as a business incubator.

I tried settling matters with a gracious payment. Shawna took my wrist before I reached my wallet. “Ask what you agreed to.” I hadn't agreed to anything. The sponsor had promised his cousin a table.

He found her another spot near his own display. Velvet got her rack back, Nia got her chair, and I experienced the supernatural sensation of a problem ending without my card being charged.

Aiden’s verdict. The fraud investigation gives the familiar partnership a pointed new case. Our visiting psychic correctly sensed tension but incorrectly assumed my wallet had signed a contract with destiny.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected exact-game publisher description of psychic fraud and Joey's secrets. No unsupported transfer of input or timing features from another Blackwell game.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/80360/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
Niggas, lights on.	Niggas, mic check.	Niggas, take turns.	Niggas, dance later.	Niggas, read first.
Niggas, pick freely.	Niggas, no rush.	Niggas, sign here.	Niggas, stay petty.	Niggas, we're good.

P019 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Blackwell Epiphany

Edition considered: PC release

Follow the Blackwell partnership toward a series conclusion, with a larger mystery about the spirits Rosa and Joey have been helping.

What you do. Continue an established investigation by following leads, examining the opening situation, and checking dialogue and saving on this particular installation.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. This bleak finale depends on earlier character history; full timing, held-input, and text-advance behavior is not verified.

Why it might click. The final Blackwell story raises the stakes around Rosa, Joey, and the nature of the spirits they help. For someone already attached to the partnership, the larger mystery offers emotional continuity and the possibility of a meaningful series conclusion.

The full catch. Destruction of souls, death, and a bleak winter atmosphere make this a darker choice. It is a later entry with accumulated character history, not necessarily the best introduction. The publisher's story description does not verify every timed, held-input, or text-advance behavior; inspect this edition directly.

Try this first. Consider whether earlier Blackwell stories sound more inviting before opening the finale. If continuing an enjoyed series, try the opening investigation and verify dialogue waiting and saving without committing to finishing its darker arc.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
Niggas, lights on.	Niggas, mic check.	Niggas, take turns.	Niggas, dance later.	Niggas, read first.
Niggas, pick freely.	Niggas, no rush.	Niggas, sign here.	Niggas, stay petty.	Niggas, we're good.

P019 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Blackwell Epiphany

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Final Revelation Is Still Not the Treaty

Blackwell Epiphany put a finale on the screen. I decided this was the right moment to announce the mystery solved. Everyone turned. It was a terrifying amount of confidence to be responsible for. “The treaty,” I declared, “is in the silver folder.” Rae asked where the silver folder was. I had not prepared a sequel to the sentence.

Nia held up a photograph of Mika carrying it. Mika remembered handing it to a person in a cape. Velvet looked offended. “A cape is not a name.”

Remy had worn one too. So had the brass greeter before Rae moved it. Tank reminded us I'd briefly worn a table runner as a presidential sash. The suspect list was expanding in textiles.

Kit found a silver folder beneath the piano bench. I nearly embraced her. It contained Mercedes's set list and a very clear note saying AIDEN DO NOT REORDER.

I put it back. Some revelations arrive with emotional closure. Mine arrived with Mercedes looking up from the piano and saying, “Nigga.”

Aiden’s verdict. The series finale belongs to its accumulated relationships and darker stakes. Our premature revelation solved nothing except whether Mercedes still needs to put my name on explicit warnings.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher description of the central threat. Series-position recommendation is editorial; no complete-path control or emotional-fit guarantee.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/236930/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
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P020 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The Shivah: Kosher Edition

Edition considered: PC Kosher Edition

Investigate a personal ethical mystery with Rabbi Russell Stone, bringing conscience, faith, and doubt into conversations within a specific New York community.

What you do. Meet Rabbi Stone, hear the premise, and make conversation choices while following a short investigation with more than one ending.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The Kosher Edition includes a distinctive conversation/combat system; later confrontation demands need checking despite the quiet opening.

Why it might click. A short-form mystery places conscience, faith, and doubt inside a specific New York community. Russell Stone's reason to investigate is personal and ethical, giving the conversations an appeal beyond collecting evidence for an abstract case.

The full catch. This card specifies the Kosher Edition, whose publisher lists revised presentation, voiced dialogue, multiple endings, and a distinctive conversation/combat system. That last feature requires checking rather than assuming all point-and-click interaction is relaxed. Death, cynicism, and moral decisions also give it a serious tone.

Try this first. Meet Rabbi Stone and hear the premise. Preview how a conversation choice works and how to save or leave; do not use the early calm as proof that the later confrontation has no timing demands.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P020 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

The Shivah: Kosher Edition

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Rabbi Has Declined My Opening Prayer

The Shivah made me consider an opening blessing for the summit. Nia asked which tradition I planned to represent. I said the broad tradition of hoping the evening cost less than expected.

“That's not a denomination,” Kit said. “It's a wish.”

Rae thought the room could use a quiet minute. Velvet thought it could use a paid performer. Rosa thought it could use people sitting down before the food cooled. None of these requests required me to invent a religion.

I asked Tank to say something meaningful. He put his plate down and thanked Rosa and the kitchen staff by name. The room actually listened.

Then he thanked whoever had hidden the bad crackers. Rae raised two fingers. Her generosity was acknowledged. Nia smiled at her across the table.

I tried adding one final thought. Shawna handed me a water glass and said, “Amen to you drinking this.” Nigga, my spiritual contribution was hydration, and the congregation seemed sincerely grateful.

Aiden's verdict. The short mystery's ethical questions have their own appeal, with its confrontation system still requiring inspection. Our invocation improved when Tank remembered actual names and I stopped improvising theology.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher's explicitly titled Kosher Edition page, including conversation/combat and endings. Timing and holds not verified; unrelated or unresolved store matches excluded.

Source 1: <https://wadgeteyegames.com/games/the-shivah/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P021 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Resonance

Edition considered: PC release

Approach a science-fiction conspiracy through four lives, using remembered subjects as conversation material rather than relying only on collected objects.

What you do. Switch between characters, inspect objects, store useful subjects in memory, and bring those subjects into conversations during the investigation.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Separate character knowledge and two memory systems create heavy bookkeeping; late action, timers, and held inputs remain unverified.

Why it might click. Four playable characters approach a science-fiction conspiracy from different lives and loyalties. The unusual memory system lets remembered subjects become conversation material, giving investigation more texture than simply collecting objects and exhausting a fixed list of questions.

The full catch. Character switching, separate knowledge, inventory and two kinds of stored memory create substantial bookkeeping. The developer's dramatic race-against-the-clock wording does not establish which passages use actual timers. Required late action and held-input demands remain unverified; this is a conditional mystery, not a no-rush certification.

Try this first. Explore one character's first available conversation and inspect how a remembered subject becomes a question. Keep a short note with that character's name and immediate objective before considering a second viewpoint.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P021 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Resonance

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / Four Witnesses and None of Them Saw My Shoes

Resonance gave us four perspectives on a conspiracy. Our missing-folder inquiry had four witnesses, which I assumed meant four times the progress. Nia said it meant four people could disagree accurately.

Mika remembered a cape. Remy remembered a silver cuff. Kit remembered the entrance music being interrupted. Tank remembered chicken. His statement was detailed and almost entirely useless.

Rae put four glasses on the table and asked everyone to stand where they'd been. I stood in the middle because the event revolved around me. Shawna moved me beside the trash can.

"That's where you were checking your shoes." "My shoes were being photographed." "By you, nigga."

From there I could see the service door. I remembered Rosa carrying the folder toward it. Rosa remembered handing it to me because my name was on the cover.

Everybody turned again. I looked down at my empty hands. Somewhere between receiving official papers and admiring my footwear, I had become both the principal witness and the fucking problem.

Aiden's verdict. The multiple perspectives and memory systems offer a distinctive investigation, with substantial bookkeeping attached. Our four-witness reconstruction has identified the host as a particularly poorly organized storage location.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Developer page supports four playable characters and the long-/short-term memory system. It does not verify a wholly untimed path. This is Wadjet Eye's adventure, not another product with Resonance in its name.

Source 1: <https://wadjeteyegames.com/games/resonance/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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P022 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

Gemini Rue

Edition considered: PC release

Follow two apparently separate lives through bleak science-fiction noir, where damaged identities and oppressive institutions make their connection worth discovering.

What you do. Investigate environments and conversations through contextual actions, following the linked stories while also facing required combat later in the adventure.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Required combat conflicts with a strict no-rush preference; accommodations described for the mobile port cannot be assumed on PC.

Why it might click. Azriel's search on a bleak colony world intertwines with an amnesiac captive's story. The attraction is adult science-fiction noir: damaged identities, oppressive institutions, rain, and uncertainty about how two apparently separate lives connect.

The full catch. This adventure includes required combat, so ordinary point-and-click investigation does not describe the complete experience. The PC interface also uses contextual actions. A publisher announcement discusses redesigned combat for a mobile port; that port's accommodations must not be assumed present on PC. A no-rush route is not established.

Try this first. If the atmosphere appeals, inspect an early investigation scene while someone checks the PC combat requirements separately. Do not treat a comfortable conversation as evidence that the later action will suit.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P022 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Gemini Rue

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Rain Machine Has No Noir Setting

Gemini Rue's bleak science-fiction mood appealed to me. I asked Mika whether the balcony could have a little rain effect for photographs. They looked at the existing puddle beneath the ice bucket. "Already arranged." "I mean cinematic rain." "Then photograph it dramatically."

Rae wanted the balcony dry because she'd parked her bike near the door. Kit wanted it dry because her entrance shoes had suede soles. Their united position failed to recognize my artistic ambitions.

Darnell offered a fog machine from his car. Mercedes said if one more person introduced a machine beside her equipment, she would start charging mechanical accompaniment rates.

I settled for a blue lamp. Remy stood beneath it in his crown and delivered a rain-soaked detective monologue despite being completely dry. Velvet supplied the rain sound with a shaker from the band.

The photograph looked excellent. I tried taking credit. Shawna pointed at the puddle. "Your contribution's leaking." Nigga, noir had become a towel assignment with flattering lighting.

Aiden's verdict. This science-fiction noir has strong atmosphere, but required combat makes its detour status matter. Our imitation achieved the rain through percussion and assigned the actual puddle to me.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

PC store supports the dual-character premise; the developer's mobile announcement explicitly confirms a combat system. Mobile redesign claims are not transferred to the PC edition. Complete PC control/timing accommodations are unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/80310/>

Source 2: <https://wadjeteyegames.com/2013/04/11/gemini-rue-now-on-the-app-store/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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P023 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Emerald City Confidential

Edition considered: PC release

Meet familiar Oz figures recast as noir suspects and witnesses, with a detective's investigation revealing complicated motives beneath storybook associations.

What you do. Talk with suspects, inspect clues, and connect information across locations while following Petra's investigation through this reimagined Oz setting.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Dialogue and puzzle connections require tracking; the source does not settle later timing, dragging, or other input requirements.

Why it might click. Petra investigates an Oz recast as a noir city, meeting altered versions of recognizable figures. The pleasure lies in the friction between childhood storybook associations and a mystery full of suspects, witnesses and complicated motives.

The full catch. Recognizable characters do not make the investigation childish or mechanically effortless. Expect dialogue, clues and puzzle connections across locations. The inspected publisher material establishes the mystery structure but does not settle every timed sequence, drag gesture or later input requirement. Treat those as checks, not absent features.

Try this first. Meet Petra and follow one early conversation far enough to decide whether the reimagined Oz feels intriguing. Inspect one clue deliberately before opening a larger chain of objectives or consulting a walkthrough.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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Niggas, we're good.

P023 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Emerald City Confidential

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / Oz Has Revoked My Emerald Credit

Emerald City Confidential recast Oz as a noir city. I had recast our sponsor lounge as the Emerald Salon, mostly by paying for green fabric and hoping nobody asked further questions.

Rae asked why the emerald chairs were plastic. “Illusion,” I said. “Invoice,” Nia corrected, holding the rental sheet.

Velvet tried the central chair and sank six inches. She stayed perfectly composed while Remy helped her up. “The wizard has furnished this palace through a clearance event.”

Kit moved one green lamp toward the stage. Mika took two fabric panels for a better backdrop. Their improvements threatened to leave my salon as three chairs around a printer.

Shawna sat in the safest chair and crossed her legs. “Looks intimate now.” I sat beside her and told her the wizard still had a few tricks. She touched my knee. “Try one that doesn't require an extension lead.”

Tank brought drinks. The salon finally had a purpose. Its sovereign was no longer making announcements, which considerably improved the local government.

Aiden’s verdict. The familiar fantasy world becomes a distinctive noir investigation, with later input questions unresolved. Our emerald palace found its proper scale at two drinks and one chair that held.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher descriptions support Petra, the Oz reinterpretation, voiced characters and investigation across five chapters. No blanket no-timer or hold-free claim is established.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/37260/>

Source 2: <https://wadgeteyegames.com/games/emerald-city-confidential/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
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P024 / A PLACE TO START

The Mermaid Mask

Edition considered: PC release; current release status verify

Investigate a captain's death aboard an eccentric submarine, where voiced suspects and an elaborate locked-room setup support a theatrical detective partnership.

What you do. Talk with suspects, examine three-dimensional clues, and compare the case file's relationships while building deductions about the captain's death.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Developer declarations support untimed mouse play, but clue manipulation gestures and the memory demands of deductions still need testing.

Why it might click. Grimoire and Sally investigate a captain's death aboard an eccentric submarine. Voiced suspects, an elaborate locked-room setup and objects to examine offer a richly theatrical detective outing, with the investigators' partnership anchoring the weirdness.

The full catch. The current PC listing declares play without timed input, mouse-only play and saving at any time. Those are developer declarations, not a personal control trial. Inspectable three-dimensional clues may still involve gestures worth testing; dialogue, case-file relationships and deductions retain a meaningful memory load.

Try this first. Enter an early conversation, inspect a clue, then test how its view changes and how the case file records it. Judge those operations before committing to solving the whole submarine's personnel problems.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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Niggas, stay petty.

Niggas, we're good.

P024 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

The Mermaid Mask

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Submarine Has a Capacity of One Host

The Mermaid Mask's submarine mystery convinced me that a round window prop would make our registration desk unforgettable. Mika asked which side people would register from.

"Through the porthole." Rae looked at the opening. "Nigga, that's a pizza hole."

Remy put his face through it and announced himself as captain of the coalition. Velvet draped a scarf over his shoulder. "You've been promoted from snack hatch." He accepted the promotion with a fanfare from his phone.

Kit wanted the circle as a moon behind her entrance. Rae wanted it gone from the signing table. A negotiation began while I was still explaining the concept of immersive arrival.

Nia proposed using it beside the stage for photographs. Mika found a stand. Suddenly everyone wanted a picture with the ridiculous captain, including me, its neglected maritime founder.

I leaned through. My lapel caught. Shawna unhooked it while Tank took the photograph. The submarine mystery now concerned whether the host could exit his own décor without professional salvage.

Aiden's verdict. The eccentric submarine case has an appealing theatrical setup; clue gestures and deductions still deserve a trial. Our vessel's first emergency involved a lapel and no actual water.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact current Steam game and SFB site confirm release, premise and developer-declared Mouse Only, Playable without Timed Input and Save Anytime. Released July 16, 2026. Object-manipulation comfort is not independently verified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1696770/>

Source 2: <https://www.sfbgames.com/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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P025 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Broken Sword - Shadow of the Templars: Reforged

Edition considered: PC Reforged edition

Travel with George and Nico through a Templar conspiracy, enjoying conversations, places, and objects in a modern visual edition of their first adventure.

What you do. Inspect nearby objects, talk with people, and connect inventory clues while revisiting places as the travel mystery expands beyond its opening.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Inventory logic can require hints; an entirely untimed, hold-free path has not been established for this exact Reforged edition.

Why it might click. George Stobbart and journalist Nico Collard follow a Templar conspiracy through a classic travel adventure. Reforged presents the first Broken Sword in a modern visual edition, retaining the appeal of conversation, places, objects and a mystery expanding beyond an ordinary trip.

The full catch. Classic inventory logic and returning to locations can require notes or outside hints. The inspected Reforged page does not establish an entirely untimed, hold-free completion path. Verify troublesome set pieces in this exact edition before recommending it for a strict no-rush requirement; older versions are not interchangeable evidence.

Try this first. Try an early safe conversation and inspect a nearby object, watching whether the interface makes available actions clear. Stop after that small investigation and decide whether the travel-mystery tone earns further checking.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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P025 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Broken Sword - Shadow of the Templars: Reforged

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Secret Order of People Who Want Their Coats

Broken Sword's Templar conspiracy made the cloakroom tokens look suspicious. Every ticket bore a little cross-shaped hotel emblem. I asked whether we had uncovered a secret society.

Kit said yes: people waiting for me to stop blocking their coats.

Rae had come for her bike lock. Nia had come for a cardigan. Velvet had come because a sponsor mistook her cape for public wardrobe. These were three distinct mysteries, and all their suspects were irritating.

I offered to investigate the emblem. Shawna turned my ticket over. My room number was written on the back in my own handwriting. "Aiden, your ancient order provides dry cleaning."

Remy found Rae's lock beneath his crown box. Nia found her cardigan exactly where she'd left it. Velvet reclaimed the cape from a man who had been photographing himself as a duke.

I told him costumes required permission. He pointed at my borrowed sash. Nigga, conspiracy is awkward when the evidence is wrapped around your middle and belongs to the catering department.

Aiden's verdict. George and Nico's travel mystery may be appealing, while the exact Reforged edition's unresolved demands remain. Our ancient order mostly wanted its coats and one stolen table runner.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Revolution's page identifies the 2024 Reforged edition and supports premise and adventure structure. Full-path timing and held-input details remain unverified; no older-edition accommodation is assumed.

Source 1: https://revolution.co.uk/games_catalog/broken-sword-1/

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
Niggas, lights on.	Niggas, mic check.	Niggas, take turns.	Niggas, dance later.	Niggas, read first.
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P026 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Broken Sword 2 - the Smoking Mirror: Remastered

Edition considered: PC Remastered edition

Rejoin George and Nico for a globe-spanning artifact mystery, where their partnership turns an isolated discovery into a larger historical threat.

What you do. Use inventory objects, revisit locations, and follow what different people know as the second adventure's mystery develops across its settings.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Remembered information and inventory puzzles add load; the Remastered edition's complete timing and holding requirements remain unresolved.

Why it might click. George and Nico return in a second globe-spanning mystery involving an artifact, criminal entanglements and a larger historical threat. The attraction is their continuing partnership and the traditional pleasure of turning an apparently isolated discovery into a much stranger story.

The full catch. The Remastered edition must be assessed on its own. Inventory puzzles, revisiting places and remembering what each person knows can become demanding. Its adventure label does not prove that every hazardous scene waits indefinitely; the inspected developer page leaves complete timing and hold requirements unresolved.

Try this first. Inspect the actual controls and one early interaction before investing in a long session. If the opening danger itself feels unwelcome, switch games rather than treating endurance as the price of seeing the later mystery.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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Niggas, mic check.

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Niggas, stay petty.

Niggas, we're good.

P026 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Broken Sword 2 - the Smoking Mirror: Remastered

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Smoking Mirror Is a Heated Vanity

The Smoking Mirror was on the screen when Kit reported smoke behind Velvet's vanity. I announced an emergency before anyone identified whether the thing was actually burning.

Velvet looked up from her chair. "It's steam, nigga. That's how fabric stops looking like your trousers."

Remy was helping with the cape while Rae tightened a loose vanity leg. Nia held a lamp at the correct angle. They had assembled an efficient little backstage crew without giving it an ancient name.

I wanted to contribute. Velvet asked me to hold the mirror. I immediately angled it toward myself. Four people watched this happen without surprise.

Shawna took a picture. "For the sequel." Kit adjusted the lamp until Velvet's reflection was perfect, then stood back to admire her work. She was competitive about lighting because she was actually good at it.

The steam cleared. Velvet looked magnificent. I looked like a man holding equipment, a role that improved the whole room whenever I remembered to face it toward somebody else.

Aiden's verdict. The returning partnership offers another globe-spanning mystery, with this edition's practical uncertainties intact. Our smoking mirror required a steady hand and an extraordinary amount of restraint from its holder.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Revolution identifies the second game's Remastered edition and artifact-led story. No edition-specific complete no-timer/no-hold route was verified.

Source 1: https://revolution.co.uk/games_catalog/broken-sword-2/

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

Niggas, pens out.

Niggas, chairs in.

Niggas, snacks here.

Niggas, receipts ready.

Niggas, lights on.

Niggas, mic check.

Niggas, take turns.

Niggas, dance later.

Niggas, read first.

Niggas, pick freely.

Niggas, no rush.

Niggas, sign here.

Niggas, stay petty.

Niggas, we're good.

P027 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Broken Sword 5 - the Serpent's Curse

Edition considered: PC complete release

Follow a Paris gallery robbery into conspiracy with George and Nico, with voiced characters and a troublesome artwork anchoring the investigation.

What you do. Question a witness, inspect gallery evidence, and connect inventory objects or testimony as the investigation expands to more people and places.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Check the installed PC edition's controls; extra features described for the separate Definitive Edition are not assumed here.

Why it might click. The fifth Broken Sword begins with a Paris gallery robbery and murder, then follows George and Nico into a conspiracy. Fully voiced characters and classic point-and-click investigation make it an invitation to follow people, motives and a troublesome work of art.

The full catch. Expect inventory reasoning and an expanding cast. Revolution lists extra interface features under a separate Definitive Edition heading; this card does not assume that those features exist in the selected PC release. Required timing, holds and speech-advance behavior need checking in the installed edition.

Try this first. Follow the first available witness exchange and inspect a piece of gallery evidence. Notice whether dialogue pace and object selection feel comfortable before adding a second location or a page of speculative connections.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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Niggas, sign here.

Niggas, stay petty.

Niggas, we're good.

P027 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Broken Sword 5 - the Serpent's Curse

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Gallery Thief Has Excellent Taste in Frames

Broken Sword 5 began with gallery trouble. Our own gallery trouble involved my giant portrait disappearing from the entrance. I found an empty easel and announced a robbery.

Rae said, “Maybe the wall filed a complaint.” Nia covered her smile with a glass.

We followed gold paint flakes toward the stage. There was my frame, surrounding Velvet's performance poster. My face had been carefully removed and placed against the wall, where it appeared to be waiting for a bus.

Mercedes had borrowed the frame with permission from the floor manager. I asked why nobody sought mine. She held up my morning message: MAKE THE STAGE LOOK EXPENSIVE. “We obeyed the nigga.”

Kit wanted the portrait moved away from the lighting cables. Remy offered to face it toward the room so I wouldn't feel excluded. Shawna suggested facing it toward the invoices so it could finally learn something.

I carried myself into the storage alcove. The gallery had improved, and its patron had become responsible for transporting the least popular exhibit.

Aiden's verdict. The gallery conspiracy invites a classic investigative outing; use the exact edition notes above. Our art theft improved the stage and left its subject carrying a surprisingly heavy ego.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Developer page supports gallery theft/murder and classic point-and-click structure. Its Definitive Edition feature list is explicitly not transferred to the unspecified complete PC edition; full timing remains unverified.

Source 1: https://revolution.co.uk/games_catalog/broken-sword-5/

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

Niggas, pens out.

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Niggas, stay petty.

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P028 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Beneath a Steel Sky

Edition considered: 1994 PC original

Explore an authoritarian machine-controlled city with Robert Foster and his robot companion in the original satirical science-fiction adventure from 1994.

What you do. Examine the first environment, distinguish inspecting from using objects, and follow an immediate objective through the older adventure's city investigation.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The older interface and navigation need a trial; mobile release features and a completely untimed path are not established here.

Why it might click. This is the original 1994 adventure: Robert Foster is taken into a city under authoritarian machine control, accompanied by the circuit board of his robot friend. Its appeal is a bleak science-fiction setting with room for satirical personality and practical investigation.

The full catch. This older adventure's interface, object logic and navigation deserve a direct trial. Abduction, violence and oppressive institutions shape the story. The developer page does not establish a death-free or untimed complete path, and its mobile release details must not be transferred to the original PC game.

Try this first. Inspect the first accessible environment and identify the immediate objective without trying to cover the whole city. Check how examining and using an object differ, then decide whether that interaction makes sense in practice.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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Niggas, stay petty.

Niggas, we're good.

P028 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Beneath a Steel Sky

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Machine Has Put Me on Hold

Beneath a Steel Sky's controlling machinery had nothing on the hotel's automated service line. It asked for my account number, room number, event number, and something called my event personality.

"Distinguished," I said. The system returned to the beginning. Tank put down his glass. "Nigga, try expensive."

Rae wanted a replacement table leg. Mika wanted a technician for the microphone. I kept demanding a supervisor, which apparently summoned a longer recording about unforgettable hospitality.

Kit found the printed staff list inside a drawer. She called the actual banquet office and described the two problems in one breath. A person answered. An actual person, with a name and a screwdriver.

While we waited, Nia slid a folded coaster under the table. Rae tested it and smiled at her. Temporary stability had become a flirtation, which was more than my account personality ever achieved.

The technician arrived before I escaped the menu. He took my phone, pressed zero, and handed it back. The future was humiliatingly local.

Aiden's verdict. The original adventure's satirical machine city is distinctive; its older interface needs a trial. Our automated system surrendered to a printed staff list and a technician named Luis.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Revolution identifies original release 1994, Foster, Union City and the AI premise. The card targets original PC, not the later mobile edition or Beyond a Steel Sky. Complete timing/death/hold behavior remains unverified.

Source 1: https://revolution.co.uk/games_catalog/beneath-a-steel-sky/

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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P029 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Kathy Rain: Director's Cut

Edition considered: PC Director's Cut

Follow Kathy's family investigation through a small town, where her grandfather's death opens secrets and the Director's Cut expands the original mystery.

What you do. Read the initial context, speak with people, and use Kathy's notebook while testing the Director's Cut's advertised single-click mouse interaction.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Family trauma and puzzle memory remain substantial; the source does not settle every late timer, chase, or held input.

Why it might click. Kathy's investigation connects her grandfather's death, family history and the secrets of a small town. The Director's Cut expands the original mystery and advertises a single-click mouse interface, making the combination of investigative conversation and a clear protagonist worth examining.

The full catch. A simpler click interface does not remove puzzle memory or emotional intensity. Family trauma and disturbing material matter here. The source does not settle every late chase, timer or held-input requirement. This is specifically Director's Cut, not an assumption that the 2016 original behaves identically.

Try this first. Read the initial context and try one conversation with Kathy's notebook close at hand. Assess both the single-click interaction and whether this family mystery feels compelling today; neither decision requires completing a case.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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P029 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Kathy Rain: Director's Cut

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Biker Has Found My Family Evidence

Kathy Rain's family investigation caught Rae's attention immediately. She pulled a chair closer while I explained that my own family history also contained mystery. Shawna said most of mine concerned receipts.

Rae asked whether the missing treaty might be in my jacket. I said I had checked. Nia asked whether I had checked the jacket I was wearing earlier.

I had worn three. Nigga, diplomacy requires options.

Kit fetched the first from the coat room. Its pocket contained a parking ticket, a lipstick-marked napkin from Shawna, and my handwritten phrase HISTORIC MOMENT, PAUSE FOR APPLAUSE. Rae read it aloud very gently, which made it worse.

Shawna reclaimed the napkin. "Private correspondence." I said it proved I was a man of deep relationships. She kissed my cheek. "It proves you were supposed to come find me before ordering more décor."

The jacket contained no treaty. It did contain the pen's presentation box, empty. Our family investigation had expanded into my habit of carrying expensive containers without their intended contents.

Aiden's verdict. Kathy's family mystery has a clear investigative personality, with its darker themes and unresolved late demands retained. My jacket investigation uncovered romance, vanity, and an impressively empty presentation box.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Director's Cut listing supports single-click interface, expanded story and family investigation. It is not a full-path accessibility audit; late required timing and holds remain unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1395030/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
Niggas, lights on.	Niggas, mic check.	Niggas, take turns.	Niggas, dance later.	Niggas, read first.
Niggas, pick freely.	Niggas, no rush.	Niggas, sign here.	Niggas, stay petty.	Niggas, we're good.

P030 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Whispers of a Machine

Edition considered: PC release

Investigate Nordic science-fiction murders with Vera, whose responses influence abilities and connect her personality to how the investigation can be solved.

What you do. Choose conversation responses, inspect Vera's available augmentations, and use abilities or clues to pursue solutions during the unfolding murder investigation.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Abilities and alternative approaches add memory demands; every required timer or held gesture has not been verified.

Why it might click. Vera investigates murders in a Nordic science-fiction world where forbidden technology and personal history intersect. Her responses influence the augmentations available for solving problems, connecting the detective's character to the practical shape of the investigation.

The full catch. Different abilities, dialogue approaches and possible solutions create more to remember than a single straightforward clue chain. The premise includes violence and grief. The inspected listing does not establish every required timer or held gesture, so character depth should not be mistaken for a simple interface promise.

Try this first. Follow an early conversation and choose the response that feels natural, then inspect how the game explains Vera's available abilities. Write down one ability in plain language instead of trying to optimize an entire personality.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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Niggas, mic check.

Niggas, take turns.

Niggas, dance later.

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Niggas, no rush.

Niggas, sign here.

Niggas, stay petty.

Niggas, we're good.

P030 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Whispers of a Machine

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Augmented Host Still Can't Find a Pen

Whispers of a Machine gave its investigator abilities shaped by her responses. I wondered what augmentation the summit would give me. Rae said a pocket that remembered what I put in it. Kit suggested directional hearing tuned to the word no. Shawna said that upgrade would change our entire marriage.

Nia wanted a pen that could make her handwriting legible. She wrote her name on a scrap to demonstrate. Remy looked at it. "Beautiful. Which kingdom?" Nia laughed and flicked the paper at him.

Rae retrieved it before it reached a puddle. She kept it beside the lamp while pretending to tidy the table. I noticed because I am a perceptive man whenever the evidence involves somebody else's love life.

Mika asked me to use that perception on the missing folder. I found a silver corner beneath a welcome bag. It was foil from a chocolate bar.

Tank thanked me for returning it. My augmentation had activated: highly selective discovery of things another nigga had already eaten.

Aiden's verdict. The detective's changing abilities may make this science-fiction case interesting, with branch and input uncertainties intact. Our host's first augmentation appears optimized for locating wrappers instead of documents.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher listing supports Vera, cybernetic abilities shaped by responses, voiced dialogue and multiple puzzle solutions. Memory rating is editorial; full-path timing and input requirements are unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/631570/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

Niggas, pens out.

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P031 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Kathy Rain 2: Soothsayer

Edition considered: PC release

Rejoin Kathy as a private investigator in 1998, following a serial-killer case where a larger city brings professional ambition and financial stakes.

What you do. Follow an available lead, talk with people, and use the notebook to organize names, places, and clues in the expanded investigation.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The larger case adds tracking and dark material; control findings from Director's Cut do not automatically apply to this sequel.

Why it might click. The sequel follows Kathy in 1998 as a private investigator drawn into the Soothsayer serial-killer case. Its appeal is an established adult lead facing a larger city, new people and a case that ties professional ambition to immediate financial stakes.

The full catch. A larger investigation means more names, locations and clues, even with a notebook to organize them. Serial murder brings dark material. The inspected store page establishes the story and notebook, not a guarantee about all late timing or input sequences. Director's Cut findings do not automatically apply to this sequel.

Try this first. Read Kathy's opening situation and investigate one available lead. Use the notebook to summarize what the lead means, then judge whether the sequel's mood and interface invite another conversation rather than another obligation.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
Niggas, lights on.	Niggas, mic check.	Niggas, take turns.	Niggas, dance later.	Niggas, read first.
Niggas, pick freely.	Niggas, no rush.	Niggas, sign here.	Niggas, stay petty.	Niggas, we're good.

P031 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Kathy Rain 2: Soothsayer

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Private Investigator Has a Public Balance

Kathy Rain's sequel gave us a working investigator with financial problems. Rae looked at the screen, then at the hotel manager approaching me. "Everybody needs a case that pays."

The manager wanted approval for a second delivery. I asked which delivery. He said the commemorative signing chairs. Kit slowly set her glass down.

"We already have chairs." "These commemorate." Nia asked what they commemorated. The treaty wasn't found, much less signed. I explained that anticipation was part of an event's visual language. Shawna translated. "This nigga ordered monograms before we agreed on initials."

Rae offered to inspect the chairs for wobbling. The manager said they were decorative. She stared. "A chair you can't sit on is a shelf with confidence." Velvet immediately wanted one as a prop, provided I paid its appearance fee.

I cancelled the second delivery. There was a cancellation charge. Tank watched me sign it. "Look at that. Your first successful investigation located exactly where the money goes."

Aiden's verdict. The sequel's working detective and larger case offer a fresh draw, without inheriting earlier control assurances. Our investigation has established that commemorative furniture can celebrate an event still missing.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact 2025 sequel listing supports 1998 setting, financial premise, Soothsayer investigation and notebook. All-path timing and held inputs remain unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1466390/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS				
Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
Niggas, lights on.	Niggas, mic check.	Niggas, take turns.	Niggas, dance later.	Niggas, read first.
Niggas, pick freely.	Niggas, no rush.	Niggas, sign here.	Niggas, stay petty.	Niggas, we're good.

P032 / A PLACE TO START

Tangle Tower

Edition considered: PC release

Investigate a mansion death entangled with a painting, meeting an animated, fully voiced cast whose expressions and relationships invite another question.

What you do. Question suspects, inspect objects closely, and compare testimony or family relationships while examining the mansion's rooms and puzzle objects.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Untimed mouse play is declared, but dragging and puzzle manipulation still need testing; relationships and testimony require attention.

Why it might click. Grimoire and Sally investigate Freya Fellow's death in a mansion where a painting appears entangled in the crime. A fully voiced, animated cast and richly drawn rooms make conversation and character observation a large part of the appeal.

The full catch. The current PC listing declares mouse-only play, play without timed input and saving at any time. Those declarations are useful but do not establish comfortable dragging or manipulation of every puzzle object. Remembering family relationships and comparing testimony still require attention; an untimed mystery can be a substantial mystery.

Try this first. Speak with one suspect and inspect one object closely enough to test selection and any manipulation. Decide whether the voices, expressions and room details make you want to ask a second question.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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Niggas, mic check.

Niggas, take turns.

Niggas, dance later.

Niggas, read first.

Niggas, pick freely.

Niggas, no rush.

Niggas, sign here.

Niggas, stay petty.

Niggas, we're good.

P032 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Tangle Tower

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Painting Has Been Holding the Pen

Tangle Tower's suspicious painting made Kit examine the frame around Velvet's poster. Something gold was wedged behind the backing. She pulled out the treaty pen with a satisfied little noise.

I applauded. Rae asked how it got there. "Temporary storage," I said. "In a painting?" "A secure cultural location."

Nia took the pen and tried it on a scrap. Her signature emerged looking like a small animal had escaped across the paper. The pen worked beautifully; its operator remained interesting.

Rae turned the scrap sideways. "I can read it." Nia raised an eyebrow. "That's either romance or an eye examination." Rae put the scrap in her pocket and declined to clarify.

Kit demanded credit for the discovery. Velvet promised to mention her during the show, provided Kit stopped aiming the entrance lamp directly into her mirror.

I reached for the recovered pen. Three hands moved first. Shawna tucked it into a plain cup on the table. Nigga, the vault had been downgraded to something I could actually see.

Aiden's verdict. The voiced mansion mystery gives observation a theatrical setting, with manipulation still worth checking. Our painting surrendered the pen and accidentally produced a much more interesting exchange beside it.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact PC listing supports premise, voices and developer-declared Mouse Only, Playable without Timed Input and Save Anytime. Gesture comfort and complete-path suitability have not been independently tested.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/359510/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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P033 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Detective Grimoire

Edition considered: 2014 PC commercial game; not Flash original

Explore an odd swamp attraction through a compact murder case, where interviews and visible conclusions challenge rumors about its unusual inhabitants.

What you do. Meet witnesses, select available ideas, and join them into small conclusions while following the commercial standalone game's murder investigation.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The puzzle interfaces need testing; the inspected listing does not confirm that every sequence avoids timers or held dragging.

Why it might click. The commercial 2014 Detective Grimoire builds a compact murder investigation around an odd swamp attraction and its inhabitants. Interviews and assembled conclusions give the detective's reasoning a visible role, while the creature rumors invite questions about what people assume and why.

The full catch. This is the paid standalone game, not the earlier browser title. Its mouse/touch-oriented design still involves connecting ideas and handling puzzle interfaces. The inspected listing does not explicitly verify that every sequence is untimed or that no drag-and-hold gesture is required; check the actual build before treating it as a sure fit.

Try this first. Meet an early witness and try forming one small conclusion from the available ideas. Observe whether selecting and joining those ideas feels natural, without imposing a deadline for reaching the correct answer.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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Niggas, stay petty.

Niggas, we're good.

P033 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Detective Grimoire

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Swamp Monster Has a Catering Badge

Detective Grimoire's swamp attraction gave me an idea for the empty decorative pond beside registration. I suggested a mysterious creature emerging during the welcome. Mika said the welcome was already late.

Tank rose from behind the pond holding a tray. "Creature's ready." He had been retrieving a dropped fork. Rosa wanted the fork washed, not mythologized.

Kit put a green lamp behind him. Velvet supplied a low dramatic note. In six seconds they produced a better monster reveal than anything I'd paid for all afternoon.

Rae photographed it for the group chat. Tank demanded approval before release. "I got sauce on my collar." Nia told him the sauce established a motive.

The catering supervisor arrived, recognized her missing tray, and ended the supernatural incident by asking Tank to carry it to the buffet. He went happily because it contained fresh food.

I proposed making this a scheduled feature. Shawna shook her head. "Let the nigga eat once without you turning it into a package." The swamp returned to decorative unemployment.

Aiden's verdict. The swamp investigation has a compact, oddball premise; its puzzle interfaces still need a trial. Our monster's motivations were refreshingly legible once somebody looked at the tray he carried.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

The 2014 commercial game's Steam listing supports the swamp case, voiced cast, conclusion system and mouse/touch design. Complete timing and held-gesture requirements are not verified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/272600/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

Niggas, pens out.

Niggas, chairs in.

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P034 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The Roottrees are Dead

Edition considered: 2025 Steam remake; not free browser original

Reconstruct a wealthy family's genealogy through a simulated 1998 internet, enjoying the moment scattered photographs and articles form a coherent family tree.

What you do. Search information, compare photographs or articles, identify a person, and place the resulting relationship into the family tree one connection at a time.

Dialogue / text choices | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Names, generations, visual identification and typing create heavy reading and memory demands; this card covers the 2025 remake.

Why it might click. The 2025 remake turns a wealthy family's genealogy into an investigation through a simulated 1998 internet. Photographs, articles and other fragments gradually identify people and their relationships, making the central reward the moment scattered information clicks into a coherent family tree.

The full catch. Names, generations, visual identification and search terms create a heavy memory and reading load. Typing and navigating the information interface matter more than reflexes in the described core activity, but that does not certify every input as effortless. This remake differs from the free 2023 browser original.

Try this first. Identify one person using one clearly connected source, then place or record that single relationship. A separate scratch note can hold a name while you test the search and family-tree interface without filling the whole chart.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

Niggas, pens out.

Niggas, chairs in.

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Niggas, we're good.

P034 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

The Roottrees are Dead

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Family Tree Has Three Catering Branches

The Roottrees' genealogy inspired me to explain the summit through a relationship chart. I drew separate circles for every caucus and immediately ran out of paper connecting the same people. Nia looked at her three arrows. "I've become a transport interchange." Remy wanted a little crown drawn beside his stage name. Kit wanted me to spell librarian correctly.

Rae took the marker and added BIKE FRIENDS beside herself and Mika. Mika collected tiny hotels but apparently also rode to work. I hadn't asked because I was busy assigning everyone ceremonial chairs.

Velvet added PEOPLE WHO REQUIRE PAYMENT across the bottom and connected half the room. Rosa drew the largest arrow. Nobody argued with the scale.

I noticed the chart was resting on a rigid silver backing. My heart jumped. It was a tray, which Tank promptly reclaimed for sandwiches.

The genealogy remained. Shawna drew a small heart between our names and then a line from mine to UNPAID INCIDENTALS. Nigga, our family tree had excellent documentation.

Aiden's verdict. The remake's family reconstruction can be absorbing, with heavy name and relationship tracking. Our summit chart grew clearer once people added their actual connections and corrected my spelling.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact 2025 Steam remake listing supports early-internet research, family-tree deduction and rebuilt interface. The memory assessment is editorial; no universal timing/hold guarantee is inferred from the genre.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/2754380/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
Niggas, lights on.	Niggas, mic check.	Niggas, take turns.	Niggas, dance later.	Niggas, read first.
Niggas, pick freely.	Niggas, no rush.	Niggas, sign here.	Niggas, stay petty.	Niggas, we're good.

P035 / A PLACE TO START

The Rise of the Golden Idol

Edition considered: PC base game

Investigate strange events in a new era of the Golden Idol format, uncovering connections between crime, belief, and institutional ambition.

What you do. Inspect crime scenes, gather useful words, and assemble explanations that connect individual incidents with broader deductions across a chapter.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Observation is described as self-paced, but names and cross-case deductions become dense; input gestures still need a trial.

Why it might click. A new era gives the Golden Idol deduction format fresh social scenery: investigators piece together strange events involving crime, belief and institutional ambition. The game invites close reading of scenes and reconstructing what happened rather than steering an action hero through them.

The full catch. The publisher explicitly describes exploring scenes at your own pace. That supports unhurried observation, not low complexity: names, collected words, connections across cases and chapter-level deductions can become dense. Input comfort and any required dragging still need a local check; dark crime scenes are central.

Try this first. Open the first case, inspect a small cluster of connected clues, and try stating aloud what seems to have happened before filling every answer. Leave the broader conspiracy for another sitting if the first scene is enough.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P035 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

The Rise of the Golden Idol

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The New Conspiracy Is the Same Expensive Host

The Rise of the Golden Idol made me suspect a second wave of hidden influence. Someone had changed the welcome slide from HISTORIC RIVALRY to GAMES, FOOD, AND A POSSIBLE AGREEMENT.

“Who authorized this?” I asked. Mika raised a hand. Then Kit. Then Rae. Then Nia. I was confronting a conspiracy with unusually accessible minutes.

Velvet said the original slide made the evening sound like a televised argument. Remy preferred the new one because possible agreement left room for his deliberately ridiculous fanfare.

I complained that the revised title lacked grandeur. Mercedes changed the font size. “There. Larger.” Rae brought the good crackers to Kit’s table. Kit moved her lamp so Nia could read. The alleged rival camps were trading useful things while I defended a slide none of them wanted.

Shawna stood beside me. “You can still introduce it.” I brightened. “Briefly.” Nigga, they had granted the founder a small ceremonial habitat with extremely firm boundaries around its noise.

Aiden’s verdict. The new deduction cases change the social scenery while keeping dense connections central. Our latest conspiracy succeeded through a clearer slide, a larger font, and fewer promises from me.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher description supports 1970s setting, twenty cases and exploration at the player’s pace. The waits label refers to scene investigation, not a tested blanket guarantee about every input or comfort need.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/2716400/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P036 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Gabriel Knight: Sins of the Fathers 20th Anniversary Edition

Edition considered: PC 20th Anniversary Edition

Follow a New Orleans writer's ritual-murder investigation into family secrets, with supernatural noir and rebuilt presentation in the twentieth-anniversary edition.

What you do. Try bookshop interactions, talk with people, and use inventory clues or remembered conversations to pursue Gabriel's developing investigation in the city.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Murder and horror are central; modern presentation does not prove that every dangerous or timed passage has been removed.

Why it might click. Gabriel's investigation of ritual murders draws a writer and bookshop owner into a family mystery in New Orleans. The twentieth-anniversary edition retells the first game with rebuilt presentation and additional material, offering a strong dose of place, conversation and supernatural noir.

The full catch. The story includes murder, horror and fictionalized religious material. Adventure puzzles can demand inventory reasoning and remembered conversations. This remake's complete path has not been checked for every dangerous or timed passage; do not assume its modern presentation removes the original design's possible pressure points.

Try this first. Try one early conversation or bookshop interaction and see whether Gabriel's personality and the setting appeal. Check the interface at the same time, keeping the first objective small rather than committing to the entire supernatural history.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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P036 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Gabriel Knight: Sins of the Fathers 20th Anniversary Edition

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Bookshop Owner Has Found My Draft Speech

Gabriel Knight's writer protagonist made Kit ask whether my welcome speech had an editor. I said I preferred an unfiltered voice. She found page four and put on her glasses.

"Your opening contains two openings." "They're complementary." "They're both about your shoes."

Remy offered to perform the second as dramatic monologue. Velvet volunteered ominous accompaniment. Before I could withdraw publication rights, he was reading MY PRESENCE HERE TONIGHT with the solemnity of a cursed duke.

Nia laughed into her napkin. Rae looked at her instead of the performer for a moment, then turned back before it became a scene. I noticed and generously refrained from announcing anything, a sacrifice nobody has properly rewarded.

Kit cut the speech down to six sentences. She kept my thank-you to Shawna, which I had written honestly before the shoes took over.

Shawna read that line and squeezed my hand. "Keep this voice, nigga." I did. The cursed duke remained available for a separate booking, according to his agent Velvet.

Aiden's verdict. The New Orleans supernatural mystery offers atmosphere and a complicated history; its dangerous passages still matter. My own writer's mystery improved after an editor removed two ceremonial shoe descriptions.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact twentieth-anniversary Steam edition supports Gabriel, New Orleans, murders and added remake material. Complete timing and held-input requirements remain unverified; fictional portrayals are not presented as cultural research.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/262000/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P037 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

Still Life

Edition considered: 2005 PC original

Compare two disturbing investigations across eras, as a contemporary FBI case and a grandfather's earlier work begin to echo one another.

What you do. Examine crime scenes and connect layered puzzle information while following the contemporary investigation and its links with the earlier case.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. A documented required robot-and-laser timing puzzle conflicts with strict no-rush needs, alongside graphic crime material and complex puzzles.

Why it might click. Two related investigations in different places and eras create the appeal: a contemporary FBI case and a grandfather's earlier work gradually echo one another. This is a dark serial-crime adventure for someone specifically interested in disturbing mysteries and historical connections.

The full catch. A contemporary review describes a required robot-and-laser puzzle that depends on timing even though it is not a simple countdown. That materially conflicts with a strict no-rush preference. Graphic crime material and layered puzzle logic add further demands; this is a clearly marked detour, not an easy recommendation.

Try this first. Start by considering the subject matter and the documented later timing obstacle. If both are acceptable with a chosen helper or shared-viewing arrangement, inspect an early investigation scene without interpreting it as the whole game's control profile.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P037 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Still Life

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Laser Corridor Leads to the Washroom

Still Life's two investigations had a difficult timing sequence in its notes. Our real-life difficulty was a decorative laser corridor I had hired for guests entering the washroom passage.

Rae stood before the red beams. "I need to pee, Aiden." I said they weren't actual security lasers. "Then stop making my bladder look like a heist."

Mika reached for the controller. Kit asked to keep the lights for the stage backdrop, where nobody had to negotiate their body through a theatrical threat to use a toilet.

Remy tried stepping through with dramatic precision. His cape caught on the stand. Velvet freed him while asking whether his kingdom possessed ordinary doors.

I helped Mika move the equipment. The beams made an excellent pattern behind the empty stage. Kit adjusted them with genuine pleasure and no further competition.

Rae returned from the newly ordinary corridor and gave us a thumbs-up. Nigga, the most successful accessibility feature I'd funded all evening was moving my own fucking idea out of the way.

Aiden's verdict. The disturbing dual investigation belongs in the detour group because a required timing puzzle is documented. Our laser corridor was considerably easier to fix: we stopped blocking the washroom.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher listing establishes the original game's dual-era crime premise. GameBoomers' contemporary review specifically reports timing-dependent robot/laser movement. No claim that this obstacle has an accessible skip is made.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/46480/>

Source 2: <https://www.gameboomers.com/reviews/Ss/Stilllifebynickie.htm>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
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P038 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Grim Fandango Remastered

Edition considered: PC Remastered edition

Travel through a distinctive land of the dead with Manny, where a compromised job expands into noir adventure, memorable characters, and music.

What you do. Explore Manny's workplace, talk with characters, and connect inventory objects while moving through the remaster's unusual world and developing story.

Mixed controls | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Indirect inventory logic can need hints; additional control schemes do not establish comfortable movement or remove every timing concern.

Why it might click. Manny's journey through a noir-inflected land of the dead combines memorable characters, an unusual visual world and a rich musical identity. The remaster refreshes presentation while preserving the adventure's central pleasure: a compromised little job opening into a much larger story.

The full catch. Traditional inventory puzzles and indirect solution logic can require considerable memory and hints. The developer confirms additional control schemes, but that alone does not establish comfortable movement or every timing requirement. Check the PC controls in practice; do not import PlayStation button instructions or assume remaster means simplified puzzles.

Try this first. Explore Manny's first available workplace interactions, compare the installed control choices, and test movement between two nearby points. Let the voice and atmosphere win your interest before agreeing to carry a long inventory of unsolved errands.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P038 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Grim Fandango Remastered

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Travel Agent Has Sold Me an Afterlife Upgrade

Grim Fandango's travel-business trouble made me inspect the hotel's event upgrade sheet. I had purchased a Legacy Welcome Experience. No one could explain what it did after the welcome ended. Tank said, "Maybe your descendants get a drink." Rosa wanted to know whether descendants also covered overtime.

Velvet liked the phrase and sang it as a lounge refrain. Remy harmonized badly on purpose. Mercedes found a chord underneath them, and suddenly my useless purchase had an actual musical identity. Kit dimmed the entrance lights to suit the moment. Rae pulled out a chair for Nia. Nia sat, still holding the recovered pen cup so I couldn't improve its storage arrangements.

I slid beside Shawna and whispered that I could sell her a private upgrade. She looked at the clock. "Does this one include the man showing up?" I promised an excellent arrival window.

The song ended before I finished explaining it. Velvet bowed. Nobody applauded the event package, but everybody applauded her. Legacy had selected a better travel agent.

Aiden's verdict. Manny's strange noir journey has strong character and musical appeal, with movement and timing concerns retained. Our legacy package finally earned applause after Velvet turned its name into a song.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

PC listing supports premise and remastered presentation; Double Fine confirms additional control schemes. Full control comfort and all-path timing are unverified. No native co-op is inferred from Remote Play Together metadata.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/316790/>

Source 2: <https://www.doublefine.com/news/grim-fandango-remastered-pre-orders-now-available>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P039 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Thimbleweed Park

Edition considered: PC release

Meet five playable oddballs in an eccentric 1987 town, where ensemble comedy and strange connections reward curiosity about people and places.

What you do. Choose Casual, follow one character's objective, and try conversations or object interactions before switching characters and managing more unfinished tasks.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Casual mode reduces some demands, but five characters and inventories still require tracking; exceptional inputs remain worth checking.

Why it might click. An eccentric 1987 town ties together five playable characters and an increasingly strange mystery. The attraction is ensemble comedy, peculiar locations and the satisfaction of uncovering connections while a traditional adventure keeps revealing another layer of oddness.

The full catch. The publisher offers Casual and Hard modes and describes exploration at your own pace. Casual is the more relevant first trial, but it does not make five characters, inventories and ongoing objectives trivial. Interface gestures and any exceptional sequence still need checking; selecting a difficulty is not a universal no-hold guarantee.

Try this first. Choose Casual and follow one character's immediate objective. Try one conversation and one object interaction, noting whether the action interface is clear before switching people or collecting a large list of unfinished tasks.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P039 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Thimbleweed Park

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / Five Witnesses Locate the Back of a Sign

Thimbleweed Park's ensemble reminded Nia that we had never finished reconstructing the folder's route. She assembled five people around the registration desk and made me keep my hands visible. Mika had given it to Rosa. Rosa had given it to me. I remembered using it to stiffen a sign. Kit remembered the sign because I had spelled her name wrong on it.

Rae turned the welcome placard around. There it was: the silver folder, taped to the back beneath a command to CELEBRATE DIFFERENCE. Tank bent over laughing.

“Nigga, you used the treaty as cardboard.” “Archival support.” “You taped international relations to a fucking easel.”

Nia carefully removed the tape while Kit held the placard still. The papers were intact. Velvet requested the discarded sign for a later joke and received unanimous approval from everyone except its author.

Shawna opened the folder. The first page said DRAFT AGENDA. No treaty yet. I had successfully lost a document that hadn't even reached the level of commitment I was claiming.

Aiden’s verdict. The eccentric ensemble may reward patient tracking; its multiple inventories still create work. Our five-person investigation found the missing draft precisely where the host had converted it into furniture.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher listing supports five playable characters, Casual/Hard modes and exploring at one's pace. Casual is an editorial first-trial choice, not proof that every interaction or entire path meets all preferences.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/569860/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P040 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

Full Throttle Remastered

Edition considered: PC Remastered edition

Follow Ben through a compact biker adventure with animated road-movie energy, distinctive characters, visual attitude, and a strong rock-music identity.

What you do. Talk with characters, investigate with inventory objects, and progress through Ben's adventure, including active road sequences beyond the quieter conversations.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Required action remains in the remaster; a complete no-reflex route or universal skip has not been verified here.

Why it might click. Ben's trouble with powerful interests unfolds through a compact biker adventure full of distinctive characters, visual attitude and rock music. The remaster restores the original game's presentation and adds archival material, preserving a very particular kind of animated road-movie energy.

The full catch. This is not solely unhurried conversation and inventory work. Its remastered road sequences retain active gameplay, and the adventure includes action demands. A complete no-reflex route or universal skip has not been verified here. Treat it as a deliberate detour if required timing is unwelcome.

Try this first. Watch or try an early quiet conversation to judge the tone, while keeping the later action warning visible. Decide separately whether someone wants to handle those sequences; shared help is an arrangement, not native cooperative play.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P040 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Full Throttle Remastered

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Biker Declines My Cavalcade

Full Throttle's road-movie attitude made me ask Rae to lead a ceremonial motorcade around the hotel entrance. She looked at me, then at the newly recovered agenda.

"Does the agenda say motorcade?" "It could." "Then keep the fucking pen away from him," she told Nia.

Remy wanted to arrive on something impressive. Velvet offered him the little wheeled costume trunk. He sat on it with his crown perfectly straight while Tank pushed him six feet and demanded a transport fee.

Kit played his victory fanfare. It was terrible, triumphant, and exactly as requested. Remy grinned so widely that nobody suggested replacing it with something tasteful.

Rae put her bike lock back in her bag. Nia asked whether she could show her the bike later. "If you like," Rae said, suddenly less fluent than she'd been about every snack in the room.

I offered to organize their viewing. Shawna took my arm. "You got an appointment with me, nigga." For once I followed the correct person through the correct door.

Aiden's verdict. The biker adventure has unmistakable attitude, with required action keeping the practical warning decisive. Our motorcade shrank to a costume trunk, and the narrator finally honored an existing appointment.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Double Fine supports the remastered game's premise; the platform interview with Tim Schafer confirms the playable Mine Road sequence's preservation. No unverified skip/no-action route is claimed.

Source 1: <https://www.doublefine.com/games/full-throttle-remastered>

Source 2: <https://blog.playstation.com/archive/2017/01/13/how-double-fine-is-tuning-up-full-throttle-remastered-for-ps4/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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A Provisional Agenda and One Very Firm Dinner Reservation

We recovered the draft from the back of the welcome sign. The pen had emerged from a picture frame. Neither discovery reflected especially well on the host, but the papers were readable, the pen worked, and Kit had successfully negotiated her name being spelled correctly in the announcement. A summit needs achievable milestones.

Shawna and I came back from the corridor a few minutes later. I had given her actual attention, which improved her opinion of the evening and temporarily destroyed my ability to remember why I had purchased a smoke machine. Tank looked at my collar. "Negotiations going well?" "Private session." "Nigga, your tie's private too. Put it back where it lives."

Nia spread the draft on the now steady table. Rae had repaired the wobble with help from the hotel technician. Kit aimed the lamp. Nobody called the arrangement historic. It simply worked. June and Dez took opposite chairs, discovered that put them too far apart to discuss the photograph, and moved closer without asking which side they represented.

The draft was ridiculous in several places. I had proposed separate victory entrances for people who belonged to overlapping groups. Remy had a paragraph describing his fanfare as obligatory. He claimed he hadn't written obligatory, only essential. Velvet crossed out both and wrote PAID SHOW FIRST. Rosa added a clear meal time. Mercedes protected her soundcheck. Mika added an actual start time and took possession of the room controls.

Kit wanted her karaoke turn. Rae wanted snacks worth eating and a table nobody had to hold upright while signing. Nia wanted her legal contribution limited to the agreement for this evening, after which she would be free to enjoy it. I said everybody wanted something. Shawna touched my arm. "Yes, baby. That's why they came." She wasn't delivering a lesson. She was asking me to stop sounding surprised.

June proposed putting the old Blue Comet claims on tomorrow's agenda. Dez objected that tomorrow had already been used as a settlement date since 1967. Nia suggested a separate little accounting session tonight. Both veterans accepted, provided it didn't interrupt the music. I sensed an opportunity to preside. Six people found useful reasons for me to remain standing away from the pen.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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Niggas, we're good.

We agreed the order of the evening: games, food, financial terms, rooms, the stage, and a final agreement only when the words were actually ready. This was a provisional agenda. Nobody signed a grand coalition treaty. Remy played four seconds of his fanfare anyway. Velvet took his keyboard, played the final note properly, and handed it back with a kiss on his forehead.

Rae offered Nia a look at her bike before the next room. Nia said yes. I nearly volunteered a photographer. Shawna tightened her hand around mine until the thought passed safely through my body without becoming a purchase.

The hotel manager arrived carrying the financial statement. June leaned over to Dez. “Second war already got a casualty.” Dez looked at the total. “His deposit.” Nigga, the next campaign had begun before I'd finished enjoying the first truce.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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The Department of Lesbian Lore Has Seized the Microphone

Aiden requested the entire history of lesbians, preferably in a font that made him look responsible. The archive declined the second condition. What follows is a substantial, selective field guide through several histories of desire, community, conflict and organizing. Its dates orient the reader; they do not rank cultures by how far they have progressed.

There is no single family tree that begins in Greece, passes through white Europe and ends by admitting everybody else. Nor can one white-butched/Black-stud rivalry explain the racial boundaries of lesbian life. Read the locally named people, organizations and records here as distinct histories that sometimes meet, rather than stages of one universal development.

Every dossier separates the historical account, a question for interpretation, the limits of the evidence, and a completely fictional summit scene. A source record may be a manifesto, an organizational self-history, an interview, an abstract or a curator's description. Those are different forms of evidence. An archive finding aid does not mean its whole collection was read.

Pleasure belongs in the history alongside organizing and exclusion. Sexual roles, gender presentation, erotic preference and identity can connect without being interchangeable. This guide discusses desire and sexual politics without converting anyone's body or boundaries into a spectacle. Aiden supplies enough spectacle already. The fictional 1967 Blue Comet war remains entirely outside the factual timeline.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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Choose a historical dossier

H01. Sappho did not leave a membership spreadsheet
Page 108

H12. Audre Lorde: desire as knowledge, pleasure as a political question
Page 119

H02. Anne Lister: a lover, a diarist, and a landowner
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H13. Chicana lesbian thought: a coalition must remember who built it
Page 120

H03. Mabel Hampton: parties, clothes and remembered words
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H14. Pleasure and danger were not obliged to become enemy nations
Page 121

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AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.
Niggas, lights on.
Niggas, pick freely.

Niggas, pens out.
Niggas, mic check.
Niggas, no rush.

Niggas, chairs in.
Niggas, take turns.
Niggas, sign here.

Niggas, snacks here.
Niggas, dance later.
Niggas, stay petty.

Niggas, receipts ready.
Niggas, read first.
Niggas, we're good.

Ho1. Sappho did not leave a membership spreadsheet

Archaic Greek poetry and its later reception

Sappho's poetry and its reception offer a starting point for a history of women's desire, not the first box in a universal identity chart. The British Library's manuscript account distinguishes the surviving fragments from later stories about the poet. Some poems concern love for women; later writers interpreted, celebrated and moralized her life in conflicting ways. Modern sapphic language draws on that legacy, but a contemporary identity vocabulary cannot simply be pasted onto an ancient social world.

The archive itself is part of the story. The Library discusses the loss, copying and difficult language of the poems, and challenges the easy tale that a single coordinated campaign of suppression explains everything missing. A fragment's survival and a later biographer's claim are different kinds of evidence. Our editorial inference: wanting an ancestor is understandable; inventing certainty about that ancestor makes the history smaller, not more intimate.

The question underneath. What do we actually know, and what have later readers wanted an ancestor to prove?

Evidence limit: Sappho is not made the origin of every culture's same-sex desire.

AIDEN HAS ENTERED THE ARCHIVE / FICTION

I unveiled the Lesbian Family Tree. It was gold, six feet tall and, because the contractor had misunderstood branching, faintly on fire.

Kit asked where I had put uncertainty. I showed her the cloakroom. June asked where I had put everybody who had never written anything down. I showed her an empty branch.

'Nigga,' Tank said, 'you bought a tree and still managed to lose the forest.'

Mika unplugged it. The historical record immediately became easier to breathe near.

Peter Toth, British Library - The Mystery of Sappho. Read scope: Curatorial manuscript essay read; no independent Greek translation or complete corpus study.

<https://www.bl.uk/stories/blogs/posts/mystery-of-sappho>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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Ho2. Anne Lister: a lover, a diarist, and a landowner

Yorkshire, 1791-1840

Anne Lister left an unusually extensive record of a woman's relationships with women alongside business, travel and everyday life. Calderdale Museums describes twenty-six diary volumes, substantial coded passages, estate management and her partnership with Ann Walker. Walker moved to Shibden in 1834. Their relationship was embedded in property, family and the possibilities available to two women with resources; those material conditions belong beside the romance.

That is a reason to resist turning Lister into a generic representative of every woman who desired women in nineteenth-century Britain. A surviving house, a large written record and the ability to travel give this life a particular visibility. The museum documents subsequent preservation and transcription work as well. Editorially, the important contrast is between a detailed individual archive and the lives a comparable archive cannot recover. Recognition need not require calling someone the first, the only, or an uncomplicated political model.

The question underneath. Whose independence also depended on property, and whose records survived?

Evidence limit: A partnership ceremony is not presented here as a modern legal marriage.

AIDEN HAS ENTERED THE ARCHIVE / FICTION

I announced that a private archive deserved a private wing. Shawna asked whether I had kept last month's electricity bill.

'That is contemporary history.'

'It is a final notice.'

Rae studied my model of the wing. 'Does the reading room need a champagne lift?'

I explained access. Nia explained access back to me, more accurately and with substantially fewer moving parts.

Calderdale Museums - Anne Lister. Read scope: Museum account and description of diary preservation read; full diaries not read.

<https://museums.calderdale.gov.uk/explore/famous-figures/anne-lister>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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Ho3. Mabel Hampton: parties, clothes and remembered words

1920s-1930s, recalled decades later

In interviews with Joan Nestle, Mabel Hampton remembered women gathering near her Harlem home for food, dancing and companionship. She described mostly Black company, while also remembering white friends from Greenwich Village. These recollections preserve a social world with interracial connections without implying that the wider city offered equal welcome. Clothing also depended on movement through public space: Hampton distinguished arriving by car from walking outside in trousers.

Hampton recalled several words used around women who loved women, including butch and sometimes stud. Her testimony records remembered usage, not a single origin or timeless definition for either term. She also described paid sewing and stage work and a lasting relationship with Lillian Foster. The resulting history includes attraction and pleasure alongside the practical arrangements that let people meet, earn money and travel together.

The question underneath. How does the route to a gathering shape who can dress freely once inside?

Evidence limit: Later-life memory contains uncertain dates; one person's vocabulary cannot establish universal historical usage.

AIDEN HAS ENTERED THE ARCHIVE / FICTION

I announced that everyone could arrive in whatever made them feel magnificent. June asked why my magnificent complimentary shuttle stopped three blocks away.

'The car photographs better beside the fountain.'

She looked at me for long enough to age the upholstery. Mika redirected the driver. June held the door while Dez climbed in wearing the disputed jacket.

'There,' June said. 'Now the freedom has transport.'

I went to tell the photographer about the fountain's unexpected independence.

Making Gay History: Mabel Hampton (authorized oral-history excerpts, 2026). Read scope: Read episode notes and the complete edited interview transcript; audio was not auditioned.

<https://makinggayhistory.org/podcast/mabel-hampton/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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Ho4. Gladys Bentley: performance, desire and the price of public visibility

1920s-1950s

In Harlem, Gladys Bentley earned her living as a blues singer and pianist through parties and nightclub appearances. Suits, a top hat and flirtation with women became elements of her public performance. The American Masters documentary places that career within entertainment opportunities for Black women, while also describing criticism from people concerned with respectable public images of Black life. Celebrity and sexual visibility could coexist with constraint.

Bentley later worked in Los Angeles and altered her public presentation. An early-1950s magazine account presented claims about heterosexual marriage and hormonal treatment; those claims do not settle her private experience. The documentary interprets this turn against repression and employment pressures. Her history therefore invites attention to who controlled a performer's livelihood and reputation, without making stage clothing a reliable certificate of either sexual orientation or a modern gender identity.

The question underneath. Who gets to read an entertainer's clothes as freedom while ignoring the conditions of her employment?

Evidence limit: Documentary interpretation and Bentley's public claims are distinguished from independently established private experience.

AIDEN HAS ENTERED THE ARCHIVE / FICTION

The costume consultant looked at Rae's shirt and began explaining Rae to Rae. It took him forty seconds to misplace an entire person.

'The shirt has a label,' she said. 'Try reading that one.'

He identified the washing temperature correctly. Velvet applauded once. Remy gave him a laundry bag instead of a microphone.

I asked whether the consultation was refundable. Nia said that depended on what I had paid him to know. Nigga, the invoice was suddenly very difficult to defend.

American Masters: Gladys Bentley: Gender-Bending Performer and Musician (PBS, 2020). Read scope: Read the complete online documentary transcript; did not watch the video.

<https://www.pbs.org/video/gladys-bentley-gender-bending-performer-and-musician-i0xlo0/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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H05. A novel reaches the prosecutor's desk

Britain, 1928

The National Archives preserves an August 1928 communication about Radclyffe Hall's *The Well of Loneliness*. Its public description identifies a letter concerning possible prosecution for obscene libel; a Home Secretary's note threatened prosecution if the publisher did not withdraw the book. The accompanying transcript excerpt notes favorable literary reviews. The document makes a specific conflict visible: literary recognition did not prevent the state from treating a representation of lesbian life as a problem to suppress.

This is a record of official scrutiny, not a complete account of Hall, her politics, the novel's readers or the eventual litigation. It also asks us to separate a work's historical importance from agreement with every idea inside it. A book can provide recognition and still use concepts its later readers dispute. That last distinction is our reading question, rather than a claim that one prosecution document can summarize lesbian literature.

The question underneath. Who gets to decide whether depicting desire is itself indecent?

Evidence limit: The legal claim is limited to the dated document, not current law or a full trial history.

AIDEN HAS ENTERED THE ARCHIVE / FICTION

I appointed myself Head of Dangerous Literature and confiscated the karaoke binder.

Kit waited until I reached the third power ballad. 'What is the alleged danger?'

'Your intention to perform all of these.'

Velvet took the binder back. 'That is a scheduling dispute, sweetheart.'

For a man with a new sash, I was learning a discouraging number of limits to jurisdiction.

The National Archives - *Well of Loneliness*, DPP 1/88. Read scope: Archive description and indexed transcript excerpt read; direct page returned 403; no complete trial-file inspection.

<https://www.nationalarchives.gov.uk/education/resources/twenties-britain-part-two/well-of-loneliness/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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Ho6. Ruth Ellis and Babe Franklin: a home with room to dance

1940s-1960s

Ruth Ellis and Ceciline 'Babe' Franklin made their Detroit home a gathering place for Black gay and lesbian people who encountered discrimination in bars. Known as the Gay Spot, it offered conversation, laughter and dancing across several decades. The Bentley Historical Library's account connects that hospitality with the couple's daily life, rather than presenting community as something created only by a formal organization or a public demonstration.

Ellis operated a printing business and darkroom from the same home, producing materials for local churches and small businesses. Work, partnership and social space were physically intertwined. Reading the house as community infrastructure is an interpretation grounded in those arrangements: people needed somewhere to gather, and someone had to sustain it. This was a household offering an alternative to commercial nightlife, not evidence that all Detroit venues shared the same exclusions or practices.

The question underneath. Whose work makes a welcoming room possible when a commercial venue closes its doors?

Evidence limit: The archival feature synthesizes earlier accounts; underlying collection boxes and the documentary were not examined.

AIDEN HAS ENTERED THE ARCHIVE / FICTION

I declared the room a historic community space. Rosa asked me to carry the folding chairs upstairs. 'Surely there is a ceremonial role.'

She handed me two chairs. 'Both hands.'

By the third trip I understood why history required refreshments. Shawna met me with water and a kiss on the cheek. I tried to turn toward the photographer without spilling either.

'Just enjoy being useful,' she said.

Nigga, it was more exhausting than being admired and significantly better received.

Katie Vloet, *Living with Pride* (Bentley Historical Library, Fall 2018). Read scope: Read the library feature, especially The Gay Spot section and its source list.

<https://bentley.umich.edu/about/collections-magazine/fall-2018/living-with-pride/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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Ho7. The founders the simplified story leaves out

San Francisco, 1955-1956

The Library of Congress's Daughters of Bilitis guide identifies Filipina Rosalie 'Rose' Bamberger as the person who proposed a private lesbian social club. Four couples met in 1955. Rose and her partner Rosemary Sliepen worked in brush manufacturing; the guide also identifies a founding participant known as Mary as Chicana. Del Martin and Phyllis Lyon became prominent figures, but prominence should not erase the other founders.

The organization's move toward public advocacy created disagreement over exposure and risk. The guide reports that working-class founders were uncomfortable with that direction. The Ladder began in 1956 and built a nationally distributed lesbian readership. This history complicates a simple story of a white middle-class movement later discovering diversity. It also complicates the idea that private social life and public activism were identical needs. Our interpretive question is material: who could afford visibility, and who stood to lose work, privacy or a place to gather?

The question underneath. When does being visible help, and who bears the cost of becoming visible?

Evidence limit: Unequal public recognition does not mean lesser participation.

AIDEN HAS ENTERED THE ARCHIVE / FICTION

The commemorative plaque arrived with my name occupying most of it. I said that was a template problem.

June asked who had booked the room, washed the cups and found the money before the template existed. I checked the plaque. There was no space left.

'Use the back,' Dez said.

'That sounds historically dangerous.'

She smiled. For once, I had learned something from an invoice.

Library of Congress - The Daughters of Bilitis. Read scope: Detailed archive research-guide text available through indexed web retrieval; original organizational records not independently read.

<https://guides.loc.gov/lgbtq-studies/before-stonewall/daughters-of-bilitis>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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Ho8. A manifesto argues that desire is political

Radicalesbians, 1970

The Woman-Identified Woman is an argument by Radicalesbians, not a neutral dictionary entry. The 1970 manifesto treats the threat of being called a lesbian as a means of policing women, including women in liberation movements. It asks women to put their relationships with one another at the center of political life. Its ambitions exceed securing tolerance for a private sexual minority.

Reading it historically also means noticing its sweeping claims about women, men, social roles and sexuality. An influential intervention need not supply the language every later lesbian must accept. We can ask what becomes possible when people refuse shame and what becomes obscured when a shared political category seems to speak for everyone. That question opens room for the racial, class and gender disagreements elsewhere in this field guide. Those are comparisons we invite readers to make; the manifesto itself does not resolve them for us.

The question underneath. What changes when a private stigma becomes a collective political name?

Evidence limit: Historical political argument; its generalizations are not adopted as biological or universal facts.

AIDEN HAS ENTERED THE ARCHIVE / FICTION

I declared that every disagreement now had political significance. Shawna asked whether that included my shoes blocking the doorway.

'Especially those.'

'Then organize them elsewhere.'

I wanted a movement. Apparently it required moving. Tank watched me carry both shoes across the room with the solemnity normally reserved for a national flag.

Radicalesbians - The Woman-Identified Woman (1970). Read scope: Selected passages of the reproduced primary manifesto, PDF pages 1-3.

https://lgbtqhistory.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/04/The_Woman_Identified_Woman.pdf

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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H09. Salsa Soul Sisters: making a community when the bars excluded you

Founded 1974; subsequent organizing

Salsa Soul Sisters formed in New York in 1974 as a community for lesbians of color. The American LGBTQ+ Museum describes racist bar practices that restricted entry or treated women of color differently once inside. Shared sexuality did not guarantee shared access. Organizing a separate space could therefore answer a concrete exclusion, while allowing members to define cultural and practical priorities themselves.

The group's activities connected poetry, music and dance with information about health and support for women entering jobs outside conventional expectations. Children and family life also belonged within that community. Archival descriptions record publications, retreats, events and meeting materials. Together these sources suggest an organization sustained through repeated work, rather than a single heroic founding moment. Its example complicates a simple opposition between social pleasure and politics: building a place to meet could involve both.

The question underneath. When does creating a separate room expand participation rather than abandon coalition?

Evidence limit: Accounts describe particular exclusions and organizational experiences, not every lesbian bar or every member's perspective.

AIDEN HAS ENTERED THE ARCHIVE / FICTION

My inclusive buffet had acquired a sponsor-only rope. Tank was on one side of it. The casserole was on the other. Diplomacy had approximately eight seconds left.

I explained that the rope was ornamental. Rosa unhooked it.

'Then it can ornament the cupboard.'

Rae took Nia a plate and asked what she wanted on it. The evening resumed its actual business. My sponsorship representative stood holding a velvet cable with no remaining social function.

American LGBTQ+ Museum, 50 Years | Salsa Soul Sisters. Read scope: Read the full anniversary article, including founders' recollections.

<https://americanlgbtqmuseum.org/salsa-soul-sisters/>

Lesbian Herstory Archives, Salsa Soul Sisters Exhibitions and Events. Read scope: Read the collection and exhibition description; individual archival items were not examined.

<https://lesbianherstoryarchives.org/salsa-soul-sisters/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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H10. The archive is also an argument about who matters

Lesbian Herstory Archives, 1970s onward

The Lesbian Herstory Archives describes its origins in groups that formed through the Gay Academic Union during the 1970s. Its mission is to preserve records of lesbian lives and make them available to future generations. The archive's own digital-resource descriptions name photographs, periodicals, organizational and personal records, shirts, buttons and newsletters. Ordinary possessions and community-made media are evidence, not merely decoration around famous lives.

The 1978 newsletter's statement of purpose makes the collecting ambition explicit: experiences omitted by dominant historical accounts should be recorded and preserved. Reading this alongside elite diaries changes the question from 'Who was exceptional enough to remember?' to 'What work lets ordinary lives remain knowable?' This is our interpretive comparison. A collection's existence does not make every past life recoverable, and the website's description is not a substitute for opening each record.

The question underneath. What counts as evidence when nobody important thought your life worth filing?

Evidence limit: The 1978 newsletter's mission statement was inspected separately; most collection items were not read.

AIDEN HAS ENTERED THE ARCHIVE / FICTION

I donated a portrait. June donated a shoebox. The shoebox immediately became more interesting. There were old programmes, a button, a photograph with writing on the back and a receipt nobody could agree about. My portrait contained only me, at an angle I had approved.

'Can the frame hold documents?' Mika asked.

Nigga, my face was one hinge away from becoming useful storage.

Lesbian Herstory Archives - Digital Resources. Read scope: Collection descriptions read; individual recordings not auditioned.

<https://www.lesbianherstoryarchives.org/digital-resources/>

Lesbian Herstory Archives - institutional history. Read scope: Mission and institutional-origin description read.

<https://www.lesbianherstoryarchives.org/>

Lesbian Herstory Archives Newsletter 4, February 1978. Read scope: Indexed text of the statement of purpose inspected; no claim of full ten-page reading.

<https://lesbianherstoryarchives.org/content/uploads/2020/06/News04.pdf>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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H11. Combahee: political theory required travel money, meals and relationships

Mid-to-late 1970s; recalled in 2003

Barbara Smith's oral history describes the Combahee River Collective and related Black feminist retreats as settings where political analysis, cultural exchange and ordinary logistics met. Participants pooled travel money and borrowed homes; serious discussion shared time with food and performances. Smith recalled Audre Lorde, Cheryl Clarke and Gloria Hull among those contributing cultural work. These recollections show ideas developing through relationships and material arrangements, not only through a finished manifesto.

Smith also acknowledged personal conflicts, including tensions around friendship, attraction and attachment, while declining to narrate private details. That boundary deserves respect: desire mattered within organizing, but it does not explain away the politics. Her account gives a useful alternative to either saintly unity or gossip. A group could produce enduring work while its members struggled with intimacy, disagreement and the pressure of depending deeply on one another.

The question underneath. How can political intimacy support collective work without turning friendship into an obligation to agree?

Evidence limit: This is Smith's retrospective account; she explicitly expresses uncertainty about the first retreat's year.

AIDEN HAS ENTERED THE ARCHIVE / FICTION

I reserved the quiet room for Advanced Theory. Three people wanted it for private conversations, and one wanted to sit without my voice coming through a speaker.

'Which one is theory?' I asked.

Mika checked the booking sheet. 'Yours is the only request that can survive in the corridor.'

Shawna found me outside rehearsing my introduction. She took my hand. 'You could spend ten minutes having a life instead of announcing one.'

Nigga, I cancelled the introduction and kept the reservation for us.

Barbara Smith interviewed by Loretta J. Ross, Voices of Feminism Oral History Project (May 7-8, 2003). Read scope: Read interview metadata and transcript pages 66-70 on conflicts, retreats and statement circulation.

<https://www.smith.edu/libraries/libs/ssc/vof/transcripts/Smith.pdf>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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H12. Audre Lorde: desire as knowledge, pleasure as a political question

1978

In *Uses of the Erotic*, Audre Lorde argues that deep feeling and the capacity for joy can inform how people judge their work, relationships and political lives. Her erotic is wider than sexual activity: she connects embodied pleasure, creative effort and the experience of sharing with others. This argument challenges arrangements that measure work only through profit or treat emotional needs as irrelevant.

Lorde writes from her position as a Black lesbian feminist and links meaningful shared experience with the possibility of collective action. She also distinguishes sharing another person's feelings from using that person, making consent part of the argument. Read historically, this is a forceful intervention into how desire and power might connect, not proof of an innate feminine essence or a checklist that every lesbian must satisfy.

The question underneath. What changes when pleasure becomes a question about meaningful work and mutuality, as well as sex?

Evidence limit: Lorde's theoretical claims are attributed to her; this reproduction is not a critical scholarly edition.

AIDEN HAS ENTERED THE ARCHIVE / FICTION

The Pleasure Committee reported that decorating my private lounge had become a joyless unpaid shift. I told them the result would be spectacular.

'For whom?' Velvet asked.

I turned toward the half-installed mirror and caught myself answering.

Rae suggested I finish the decorations while everyone else tried a game. Shawna left me one uninflated balloon. 'Start with a small ambition.'

Nigga, I had funded a committee that could recognize bad work immediately. It was proving expensive in ways I had not budgeted.

Audre Lorde, *The Uses of the Erotic: The Erotic as Power* (public reproduction excerpted from *Sister Outsider*). Read scope: Read all three pages of the reproduced essay; no authoritative-edition collation was performed.

https://mamagenas.com/wp3/wp-content/uploads/2016/M16/Uses_of_the_Erotic.pdf

University of Waterloo, (1978) - *Uses of the Erotic* - Audre Lorde. Read scope: Read the catalogue entry to confirm the 1978 date.

<https://uwaterloo.ca/equity-diversity-inclusion-anti-racism/catalogs/educational-catalogue-resources/1978-uses-erotic-audre-lorde>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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H13. Chicana lesbian thought: a coalition must remember who built it

1981 anthology; Moraga's 2015 retrospective, reprinted in 2016

Cherríe Moraga's Chicana lesbian writing places sexuality beside language, family and political belonging. She coedited *This Bridge Called My Back* with Gloria Anzaldúa in 1981, assembling different literary and artistic forms around women of color's lives. This was a coalition project, not a claim that every contributor occupied the same position. Moraga's own work moves between Spanish and English, poetry and prose, making form part of the encounter rather than treating theory as something detached from a life.

In a later preface excerpt, Moraga argues that political memory matters: movements lose something when each generation imagines itself the first to invent resistance. Her argument connects intimate and institutional conflicts with work, migration and place. Read together, these selected sources suggest a demanding question for coalition: whose lived knowledge becomes the foundation, and whose becomes an optional addition? That is our synthesis of the excerpts, not a summary of every essay in the anthology.

The question underneath. Who gets treated as a source of political theory, and who is merely invited to supply an illustrative personal story?

Evidence limit: This is a US Chicana contribution to a wider coalition, not a substitute for every Latina or Latin American lesbian history.

AIDEN HAS ENTERED THE ARCHIVE / FICTION

I had invented coalition before lunch. By dinner, Kit had found three books and two people who could explain why my announcement was late.

I offered to call it a reimagining. June offered to call it reading.

The reading list was under the buffet's short leg. Rae retrieved it, repaired the table and asked whether my keynote had any other structural applications.

Nigga, I gave the first ten minutes to somebody who had arrived knowing something.

Cherríe Moraga, *Catching Fire - La Voz de Esperanza*, March 2016, excerpt from the fourth-edition preface. Read scope: One-page scan of printed pages 2-3; read Moraga's excerpt and its permission note, not the complete preface or anthology.

<https://thisbridgecalledcyberspace.net/FILES/3904.pdf>

Haymarket Books - *Loving in the War Years: And Other Writings*, 1978-1999. Read scope: Publisher's description and edition metadata; no full-book reading claimed.

<https://www.haymarketbooks.org/books/2006-loving-in-the-war-years>

Gloria E. Anzaldúa Literary Trust - *This Bridge Called My Back*. Read scope: Book description, publication history and coalition discussion; no anthology chapters read through this page.

<https://gloriaeanzaldua.com/this-bridge-called-my-back/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
Niggas, lights on.	Niggas, mic check.	Niggas, take turns.	Niggas, dance later.	Niggas, read first.
Niggas, pick freely.	Niggas, no rush.	Niggas, sign here.	Niggas, stay petty.	Niggas, we're good.

H14. Pleasure and danger were not obliged to become enemy nations

Barnard sexuality conference, 1982

Barnard's retrospective account describes the 1982 Scholar and Feminist conference as a flashpoint in arguments over sexuality. The planners wanted to address both sexual violence and women's right to pleasure. A diary documenting preparation, writing and artwork became the focus of controversy; the college attempted to confiscate it and later paid for a reprint without its name. The institutional response belongs to the history of the argument, not just its publicity.

The retrospective criticizes a division that framed participants as either pro-sex or anti-violence. That opposition concealed the conference's attempt to think about both. This does not mean all positions were compatible or that harms were imaginary. It gives our fiction a better problem than 'the fun lesbians defeat the prudish ones': how can people discuss coercion, erotic possibility and unequal power without pretending one concern automatically answers the others? The question remains a question rather than an official verdict on the entire feminist sex wars.

The question underneath. Who gets lost when pleasure and protection are treated as mutually exclusive loyalties?

Evidence limit: This account is one retrospective perspective on a larger, contested history.

AIDEN HAS ENTERED THE ARCHIVE / FICTION

I commissioned two lecterns: FUN and SAFETY. They arrived bolted together.

'A manufacturing mistake,' I said.

Nia put her notes across both. 'Leave it.'

Darnell offered to improve the discussion with cocaine. Shawna moved his proposal away from the pastries. Velvet asked whether anybody had considered being outrageous while still listening when another person said no.

The contractor sent an invoice for innovative joinery. For once, I paid without a speech.

The Scholar and Feminist Online - retrospective introduction to thirty years of the conference. Read scope: Institutional retrospective's 1982-conference passages read; full conference proceedings not read.

<https://sfoonline.barnard.edu/sfxxx/printjja.htm>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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H15. Punk, clubs, sex and politics occupy the same room

Rebel Dykes, London, 1980s-early 1990s

Bishopsgate Institute's Rebel Dykes collection describes a network of lesbians and punk women in London whose lives connected art, music, club nights and political organizing. The archive names activity around Greenham Common, the South London Women's Hospital occupation, anti-censorship, sex workers' rights, opposition to Section 28 and HIV/AIDS activism. Its holdings include footage, images and later oral histories connected with Chain Reaction and the SM community.

The useful point is not that this network represents all British lesbians or that everyone agreed about sex. A locally specific scene can combine pleasure, practical mutual reliance and controversial politics. A club is not necessarily a holiday from history; it can be one of the places history is made. That interpretation also resists flattening the past into either respectable petitioners or a costume party. Here the details are drawn from the collection description, while the recordings themselves remain a further-reading route.

The question underneath. What kinds of organizing become visible if the dance floor counts as a serious place?

Evidence limit: A particular London network, not a universal account of lesbian sexual culture.

AIDEN HAS ENTERED THE ARCHIVE / FICTION

I asked Velvet to recreate a historic underground club. She asked how underground I meant. I pointed to the penthouse.

'You mean exclusive.'

'It has an elevator.'

'Those are different problems.'

Remy tested the speakers. The bass shook a small gold plaque off my portrait. The room voted, without holding a vote, that this was the best use of the sound system so far.

Bishopsgate Institute - Rebel Dykes Archive. Read scope: Administrative history and scope/content description read; oral histories and film not watched.

<https://www.bishopsgate.org.uk/collections/rebel-dykes-archive/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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H16. Women were people with AIDS, organizers and caregivers

ACT UP and women's AIDS activism, late 1980s-1990s

The ACT UP Oral History Project's Women & AIDS page insists on several roles at once: women living with AIDS, movement leaders and caregivers. Its materials describe organizing over the CDC definition of AIDS, women's access to services, prison conditions and peer support. The page also identifies work by Maxine Wolfe, Sarah Schulman, Catherine Gund and other participants. A lesbian history that mentions only care for gay men would miss the political agency and varied lives represented here.

The site is an activist archive, and its framing should be identified as such. For this guide, the inspected evidence is its descriptions of films, printed materials and campaigns; we did not watch every recording. Our interpretive connection is to coalition work: sharing a movement does not guarantee that everyone's urgent needs appear in its public story. Counting people, funding services and changing institutional criteria are also political acts. This is historical context, not present-day medical advice.

The question underneath. Who becomes a patient, a leader or only somebody else's helper in the movement's memory?

Evidence limit: No claim that all women in this archive were lesbians; no simplistic origin story for acronym order.

AIDEN HAS ENTERED THE ARCHIVE / FICTION

My first coalition report had a section called Supportive Ladies. Nia drew one line through the heading.

'Where are the decision-makers?' she asked.

I pointed at the same names.

'Then why did you write this?'

I blamed the software. Kit rotated the laptop toward me. The offending phrase was still selected, and my hands were still on the keyboard. Nigga, technology had become a witness for the prosecution.

ACT UP Oral History Project - Women & AIDS. Read scope: Curatorial descriptions and identified campaign/media records read; videos not auditioned.

<https://www.actuporalhistory.org/actions/women-aids>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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H17. Wabanaki perspectives: a shared term does not erase a nation's own names

1990 terminology milestone; Wabanaki organizing from 2009

The Wabanaki Two-Spirit Alliance explains that Two-Spirit was introduced at the 1990 International Indigenous Lesbian and Gay Gathering in Winnipeg. A shared term could support reclamation without replacing the names, teachings or roles of individual nations. Its account connects identity with kinship, land, language and responsibilities; a translation concerned only with sexual attraction would miss part of what is being described.

The Alliance traces its own beginnings to a 2009 gathering responding to isolation and loss, while emphasizing cultural connection, celebration and life. It includes people who name themselves in several ways. Some Indigenous people identify as lesbian or queer without identifying as Two-Spirit; neither label authorizes an outsider to assign the other. For a lesbian history appendix, this is a necessary boundary as well as a connection: solidarity can support another community's self-definition without absorbing it into a familiar identity category.

The question underneath. Can a coalition share resources without demanding that every participant translate themselves into its organizer's preferred categories?

Evidence limit: Two-Spirit is not a universal Indigenous identity or a synonym for lesbian; this account reflects one regional alliance.

AIDEN HAS ENTERED THE ARCHIVE / FICTION

My universal label maker ran out of space after the first person introduced themselves. I offered abbreviations.

Mika offered the off switch. Nia asked why a machine I had bought ten minutes ago should have more authority than the people standing in front of it.

I said the manufacturer called it professional. Kit printed AIDEN on a blank card and handed me a pen.

The remaining space was for whatever I learned next. It was a humiliatingly large card.

Wabanaki Two-Spirit Alliance - Understanding the Term Two-Spirit. Read scope: Definition, 1990 gathering account, historical context and self-naming guidance; nation-specific vocabulary lists not generalized.

<https://w2sa.ca/two-spirit-library/understanding-the-term-two-spirit>

Wabanaki Two-Spirit Alliance - The Story of W2SA. Read scope: Community description, purpose, 2009 origin account and cultural-gathering history.

<https://w2sa.ca/about>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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H18. Visibility becomes an action, not a compliment

Lesbian Avengers, 1992-1993

The Lesbian Avenger Documentary Project dates the New York group's beginnings to 1992 and names six experienced founders: Ana Simo, Sarah Schulman, Maxine Wolfe, Anne-christine d'Adesky, Marie Honan and Anne Maguire. Its account connects the first action to the fight over Queens's multicultural Children of the Rainbow curriculum and to frustration with lesbian invisibility. Media and visually striking action were tools, not incidental decorations.

The project describes the 1993 Washington Dyke March as a major moment in the group's expansion. Reading its own history shows both specificity and circulation: a local strategy could inspire other chapters without giving a single office ownership of every lesbian demand. Our editorial question is about who is seen and on whose terms. Visibility can mean appearing in somebody else's photograph, or deciding what action puts a previously neglected issue in front of the public. Those are not interchangeable achievements.

The question underneath. Are people merely visible, or do they control what the public is being asked to notice?

Evidence limit: The account calls itself incomplete; chapter experiences should not be treated as identical.

AIDEN HAS ENTERED THE ARCHIVE / FICTION

I offered the coalition a publicity package. Velvet asked what it contained.

'My face, but supportive.'

She asked again.

'A larger version for outdoor use.'

Mika turned my easel toward the wall and handed the performers the programme. The publicity improved so quickly I briefly suspected sabotage. Tank assured me that, in this case, those were the same event.

Lesbian Avenger Documentary Project - A Brief History. Read scope: Participant documentary project's organizational account read; no complete archive or film viewing.

<https://www.lesbianavengers.com/about/history.shtml>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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H19. Gauteng: Nkateko and the placards that remain

1996-1998

GALA's guide records Nkateko, founded in Gauteng by Beverley Palesa Ditsie in 1996. It describes the constituency using period language for Black lesbian, bisexual and transgender gay women. The group participated in Johannesburg Pride in 1997 and dissolved in 1998. Collection AM 2661 contains organizational information and 22 handmade placards from that Pride.

This modest inventory changes what a historical story can notice. A short-lived organization can leave evidence of collective expression without becoming a lasting institution. The placards invite investigation of how participants presented themselves, although we read the catalog rather than the signs. Our interpretation remains limited: traces of agency and gathering cannot supply the group's complete internal history. Its disagreements, pleasures and reasons for ending remain questions to explore in the collection.

The question underneath. Which movements disappear when longevity and famous leaders determine what counts as historically important?

Evidence limit: Historical group terminology does not establish every participant's identity or explain the dissolution.

AIDEN HAS ENTERED THE ARCHIVE / FICTION

I ordered a bronze monument to the summit. June collected the handwritten signs. Her collection could tell you what people had asked for. Mine could tell you my preferred jawline.

The foundry called about the deposit. I asked whether they could cast a cancellation instead.

'Keep the invoice,' Dez said. 'You never know what idiots will make historically significant.'

Nigga, I filed it flat and checked both sides.

GALA Queer Archive - Collection guide, Nkateko AM 2661. Read scope: Nkateko entry, printed pages 59-60 of currently served PDF; objects not inspected.

<https://gala.co.za/wp-content/uploads/2021/08/GALA-Archival-Guide-20210825.pdf>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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H2o. Kolkata: support, public argument and a magazine in one's own voice

1999-2004 founding and early publishing milestones

Sappho began in Kolkata in June 1999 as a self-support group for lesbians, bisexual women and transmasculine people. The organization's retrospective describes a wish to share ordinary dreams and difficulties as well as desire. Sappho for Equality followed in October 2003 as a platform connecting community support to rights and wider social participation. These are related developments with different dates, not interchangeable names for a single founding moment.

In January 2004, the group published the first Swakanthey, its bilingual magazine, and distributed it at Kolkata's book fair. Art, poetry, prose and articles offered a public creative voice beyond organizational announcements. This history holds a useful tension: people may need an intimate place to belong and also want to address audiences beyond it. The group's account includes debating and revising its own approach; it is not a tidy march from private silence to a finished public freedom.

The question underneath. How can a group speak publicly without making public visibility a condition of receiving friendship and support?

Evidence limit: This Kolkata account cannot represent all of India or South Asia; transmasculine participants must not be relabeled as lesbians.

AIDEN HAS ENTERED THE ARCHIVE / FICTION

The first issue of our summit magazine had twelve photographs of me and a generous half-column reserved for everybody's voices.

Mercedes asked whether voices came in smaller sizes now. Velvet laid her performance photograph over my centerfold. Remy placed a drawing on top of my chairman's message.

Shawna found the one picture where I was actually helping. They kept that one.

My publishing career survived, substantially reduced in square footage.

Sappho for Equality - About Us. Read scope: Organization's Sappho and Sappho for Equality histories, including June 1999 and October 2003 milestones.

<https://www.sapphokolkata.in/about-us>

Sappho for Equality - 2003 Landmarks. Read scope: Inception and support-to-entitlements discussion; counseling chronology read but not evaluated as clinical evidence.

<https://www.sapphokolkata.in/our-journey/details/69>

Sappho for Equality - 2004 Landmarks. Read scope: First Swakanthey publication and book-fair account; the magazine's individual issues were not read.

<https://www.sapphokolkata.in/our-journey/details/67>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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H21. The Philippines: GALANG puts economic life inside sexual politics

2008 founding and the organization's subsequent program account

GALANG describes beginnings in conversations among lesbian friends and its registration in the Philippines in August 2008. Its founders wanted organizing to confront the relationship between sexuality and poverty. The organization identifies itself as lesbian-initiated and lesbian-run, working with lesbians, bisexual women and trans men in urban poor communities. Its account therefore places employment, services and material resources inside the discussion of sexual and gender freedom.

The program description joins community leadership training and participatory research with policy advocacy. It also lists Tatsulok Komiks, a lesbian comic-book series, among its educational materials. Creative storytelling belongs here alongside practical organizing, rather than appearing only after material needs have been solved. These sources describe an organization's purposes and methods, not an independent evaluation of its results. Their challenge to this appendix is concrete: an account of recognition remains incomplete if it never asks how people gain the resources to live and organize.

The question underneath. What changes when a sexual-freedom agenda treats access to work and services as central rather than supplementary?

Evidence limit: The organization does not stand for every Filipino community; an alliance among LBT people does not erase their different identities.

AIDEN HAS ENTERED THE ARCHIVE / FICTION

The gold-plated Visibility Award cost more than the transport reimbursements. The volunteers noticed because the reimbursements had not happened.

I proposed a photograph with the award. Rosa proposed paying people.

Shawna turned the trophy upside down and read the return policy. The cashier asked why I was returning it. I said we had discovered a more practical form of recognition.

Nigga, a bank transfer had none of the trophy's sparkle and considerably more fans.

GALANG Philippines - About Us. Read scope: Full organization-authored About text returned by search index; founding account and constituency, excluding undated poverty statistics.

<https://www.galangphilippines.org/about/>

GALANG Philippines - What We Do. Read scope: Full indexed program description: capacity building, advocacy, research and institutional development; comics themselves not read.

<https://www.galangphilippines.org/about/what-we-do/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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H22. Stone is not the final boss of masculinity

Contemporary terminology, with historical inheritances

Ro White's Autostraddle discussion draws on interviews and earlier lesbian writing to describe variation in stone identities. Some people use the word for firm limits on receiving sexual touch; others describe more specific boundaries. The article cautions against assuming that every stone person has the same explanation, history or relationship to gender. Its contemporary testimony is useful precisely because it does not yield a single personality profile.

For this book, the distinction is between self-description and an outsider's prediction. Clothes, confidence, race or a partner's femininity do not tell another person what contact is wanted. Nor is changing someone's boundary a romantic achievement. Those are ethical conclusions we bring to the fiction, rather than instructions for an intimate act. A reader can learn vocabulary without treating it as a license to interrogate a stranger. The term may help someone communicate; the actual person still supplies the meaning that matters in that relationship.

The question underneath. Does a label help a person speak, or are you using it to stop listening?

Evidence limit: This is non-graphic discussion of identity, desire and boundaries; terminology varies.

AIDEN HAS ENTERED THE ARCHIVE / FICTION

I had designed a masculinity leaderboard. At the top was a photograph of a very large boot.

Rae asked what the boot had consented to. I said the image was licensed.

'Different question,' Nia said.

Kit liked the boot. June hated the heel. Shawna asked why a chart about other people had my signature across it.

Nigga, I deleted the ranking. The boot remained handsome and entirely unavailable for comment.

Ro White - The Gay B C's of Sex: S Is for Stone. Read scope: Article text including first-person interview accounts inspected through indexed retrieval; no participant treated as representative of all stone people.

<https://www.autostraddle.com/stone-butch-definition/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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Cultural reading notes

These are cultural reading notes, not a taxonomy of people. The dialogues are original fiction: each character has a partial perspective and no character speaks for an entire community. The fictional 1967 feud is not actual LGBTQ history. The notes below distinguish what was inspected from what was not.

C1. Black lesbian gender and sexual culture: celebration and resistance

Wilson's qualitative study describes gender and sexual roles in one African American lesbian community as sources of both expectations and resistance. That situated finding cautions against treating a character's label as a universal rule about behavior, desire or power.

Read scope: Abstract only; full article not inspected for this revision.

<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/19296308/>

C2. Brown Boi Project - About Us

The organization describes work among masculine-of-center women and queer and trans people of color across racial and gender justice. Its account helps frame masculinity as something people can enjoy, examine and change without assuming identical experiences or power.

Read scope: Organizational self-description and participant testimony on the About Us page.

<https://www.brownboiproject.org/about-us.html>

C3. The Combahee River Collective Statement

The collective connects race, gender, sexuality and class, and pairs solidarity with criticism of sexism. Its position informs the distinction between cooperation and erasure of internal conflict. It is a specific 1977 political statement; it is not evidence for the invented 1967 feud.

Read scope: Selected sections of the primary statement, especially pages 1-4 of this reproduction.

https://lgbtqhistory.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/04/Combahee_River_Collective_Statement.pdf

C4. Stone Butch Blues - selected author notes

These notes emphasize context, changing terminology, self-definition and collective connection. They provide a reason to let different generations use language differently, rather than force every fictional person into a single present-day vocabulary. The novel's scenes and prose are not reproduced.

Read scope: Selected author notes, printed pages 333-335 / PDF pages 350-352. No fresh full reading of the novel is claimed.

<https://www.lesliefeinberg.net/wp-content/uploads/2015/08/Stone-Butch-Blues-by-Leslie-Feinberg.pdf>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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C5. What Is a Stud? The History of Black Lesbian Masculinity

The interviewees describe varied personal expressions of stud identity, including nonbinary experience, within Black queer culture. These accounts resist a checklist of clothes, sexual roles or personality traits. The fictional Rae speaks for herself.

Read scope: Brief use of first-person interviews with Cortney Matthewis and \$leazy EZ; no interview quotations reused.

<https://www.them.us/story/what-is-a-stud-the-history-of-black-lesbian-masculinity>

C6. The Gender of Desire: Joan Nestle's Last Interview - Our Dyke Histories

Nestle's first-person account brings pleasure, class, race and risk into the same social world. It helps foreground femme desire and agency, rather than making a femme character a passive partner or a reward. No interview scene or erotic passage is adapted.

Read scope: Selected written interview/transcript passages; audio not auditioned.

<https://www.queergeographies.com/the-gender-of-desire-joan-nestles-last-interview/>

C7. Mabel Hampton Oral History Project - Reflections on Lesbian Fashion

The exhibit's presentation of Hampton helps check against erasing Black butch lives or equating butchness with whiteness. Clothing and self-description belong to a particular life. June is an invented character, not a portrait of Hampton.

Read scope: Curatorial descriptions inspected; recordings not auditioned and no new transcript made.

<https://herstories.prattinfoschool.nyc/omeka/exhibits/show/reflections-on-lesbian-fashion/mabel-hampton-oral-history-pro>

C8. Sylvia Rivera's 1973 speech - transcript in Document Set 3

Rivera's speech challenges exclusion within a movement and asks who provides material support to vulnerable community members. It informs the coalition's concern with paid work, resources and accountability. Rivera does not appear in the fiction, and no speech is assigned to a fictional character.

Read scope: Speech transcript on PDF page 2. The packet's Stonewall biographical claim is not relied upon.

<https://teachrock.org/wp-content/uploads/Document-Set-3-Sylvia-Rivera.pdf>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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Credits, source limits and the paperwork we actually mean

Creative direction: Nolan. The Second Great Butch vs. Stud War / Coalition Edition: new ChatGPT-generated comic prose and production, retaining the researched game cards and selection mechanics. This is a separate user-directed alternate companion; previous editions and source novels remain intact. All fictional participants are adults; Lillian remains the reader.

Revision base: the Tellings Cut at Sodelin/Ten-Toes-Down commit 0e3fd666e7e1a0907e1e4dcd8ed3213cfee79a04. The earlier edition was grounded in sampled Niggatorial Tellings passages. The new summit cast, caucuses, romances and treaty are original companion fiction; they are not represented as recovered source canon. Editorial notes record the reading and rewriting scope.

The optional traits, tokens and signed-dice layer take inspiration from Fate. The Panorama's catalogue coordinates, vetoes, snack amendment, incidents and appeals are original comic selection rules; this is not a substitute for the Fate rulebooks.

Fate reference pages consulted:

<https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/how-do-stuff-outcomes-actions-and-approaches> and

<https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/aspects-fate-points>. No Fate logos, illustrations or fonts are used.

This work is based on Fate Core System and Fate Accelerated Edition, products of Evil Hat Productions, LLC, developed, authored, and edited by Leonard Balsera, Brian Engard, Jeremy Keller, Ryan Macklin, Mike Olson, Clark Valentine, Amanda Valentine, Fred Hicks, and Rob Donoghue, and licensed for our use under the Creative Commons Attribution 3.0 Unported license (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0/>).

Game titles identify the corresponding games. No game code, ROMs, full manuals or third-party artwork are included. Availability and controls can vary by edition, region and platform. The sources support their stated claims; no purchase, installation or personal fit has been established by this book.

This edition includes frequent non-hateful reclaimed in-group language, strong profanity, fictional cocaine references and consensual non-graphic sexual innuendo. The fictional crew chorus intentionally repeats the reclaimed plural fifteen times on each fixed PDF page, separate from game facts. EPUB pagination is reflowable; its chorus appears at chapter boundaries. Fiction does not describe developers, real readers or entire identity groups.

The First Great Butch vs. Stud War of 1967, the Blue Comet Social Club, its veterans and the present summit are fictional. They are not claims about actual LGBTQ history. The book uses overlapping personal identities and individual disagreements rather than treating butches, studs, lesbians, drag performers and trans people as mutually exclusive populations.

Each case names its inspected sources and the limits of those sources. Store descriptions and developer feature declarations are not a playthrough of every route. The companion evidence ledger records editorial tags separately from source declarations. Availability and features may change after the check date.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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